玄德

xuande



HOMO RECIPIENS

Ursula K. Le Guin and the Counter-Anthropology of the Open Hand

TAOIST ONTOLOGY · ANARCHIST PRAXIS · ETHNOGRAPHIC IMAGINATION · FEMINIST POETICS
AS THE GROUND OF A RECIPIENT HUMANISM

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the oeuvre of Ursula K. Le Guin (1929–2018), customarily parsed into discrete "influences"—Daoist, anarchist, anthropological, Jungian, feminist, ecological—constitutes a single, internally articulated counter-anthropology: a sustained answer, across fiction, essay, translation, and verse, to the question of what kind of being the human is. The dominant lineage of Western humanism, from the Promethean myth through Pico della Mirandola, Bacon, Locke, and the existentialist *projet*, has figured the human as a *projectile* (*pro-icere*, "to throw forward"): the being that strikes, advances, appropriates, and owns itself. Le Guin elaborates its counter-figure, which I term the *recipient* (*re-cipere*: "to take back," "to receive," and, in juridical Latin, "to take upon oneself, to warrant"): the being that receives, holds, carries, keeps in trust, and lets go.

Taking the *Daodejing*'s formula of "mysterious virtue" (*xuande* 玄德)—to generate without possessing, to act without presuming, to raise without ruling (chs. 10, 51)—as the ethical kernel of the corpus, the dissertation reconstructs the convergence of Le Guin's sources into a single structure: Laozi and Zhuangzi; the pacifist anarchism of Godwin, Shelley, Kropotkin, Goldman, Landauer, and Paul Goodman; the Boasian anthropology of Alfred and Theodora Kroeber, shadowed by the death and dismemberment of Ishi; Jung's psychology of the shadow; and the paleoanthropological counter-narrative of Sally Slocum and Elizabeth Fisher. That structure has three negative moments—*dispossession* (economic), *unnaming* (epistemic and linguistic), and *de-heroization* (narrative and mortal)—and one positive practice, holding without having, which unfolds in four movements: receiving, holding, carrying, releasing. Each movement has its corruption: appropriation (the collection), hoarding (the hoard), confinement (the cage), abandonment (the walk-away). The wall—a membrane that has hardened—is the general form of all four.

The argument yields several new readings. Gethenian kemmer is read as *received sex*, a position irreducible either to biological essentialism or to performative self-authorship. *Tehanu* (1990) is read as Le Guin's revision of "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973): an ethics of exit is superseded by an ethics of carrying, with "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) as the hinge. *The Other Wind* (2001), in which the dead are released from a walled afterlife, is set against the museum logic exemplified by the retention, and the 2000 repatriation, of Ishi's brain. Arendt's twin faculties of promising and forgiving are mapped onto *The Dispossessed* and *Four Ways to Forgiveness*. A set of philological convergences anchors the argument: Legge's "lathe of heaven" displaces Zhuangzi's potter's wheel (*tianjun* 天鈞); the primordial Hundun is a faceless sack that sings; Aristotle defines the vessel as a place that can be carried; Erasmus turned Pandora's storage jar into a box; Rabelais built Thélème without walls; Dante defined the vernacular

as the tongue we *receive* (*accipimus*) from the nurse; Bloch's *Heimat* and Shevek's "home" are both places where no one has yet been.

The dissertation concludes by formalizing a *recipient humanism*. Distinguished from Promethean and possessive humanisms, from care ethics, from posthumanism, and from Butler and Athanasiou's theory of dispossession, it retains the specificity of the human as the maker of vessels, promises, and stories while dissolving sovereignty over self, other, and world. Its emblem is the empty hand that closes *The Dispossessed*: empty not as deprivation but as the precondition of every holding.

Note on Texts, Citation, and Method

Because Le Guin's major fictions circulate in many paginations, novels are cited by abbreviation and chapter (*TD* ch. 1), stories and essays by title and collection, and the *Daodejing* (*DDJ*) and *Zhuangzi* (*ZZ*) by chapter in the received recensions (the eighty-one-chapter Wang Bi text; Guo Xiang's thirty-three-chapter *Zhuangzi*). Unless otherwise noted, renderings from Classical Chinese, Greek, Latin, French, and German are my own. Pinyin is used throughout, except where Le Guin's Wade-Giles forms (Lao Tzu, Chuang Tzu, *Tao Te Ching*) stand in her titles. Quotation from Le Guin is restricted to brief phrases; the argument proceeds by paraphrase and structural description. Secondary and theoretical sources are cited author–date against the Works Cited.

ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Work	First published
ACH	*Always Coming Home*	1985
DEW	*Dancing at the Edge of the World* (essays)	1989
EoH	*The Eye of the Heron*	1978
FS	*The Farthest Shore*	1972
FWF	*Four Ways to Forgiveness*	1995
LHD	*The Left Hand of Darkness*	1969
LN	*The Language of the Night* (essays)	1979; rev. 1992
LoH	*The Lathe of Heaven*	1971
OW	*The Other Wind*	2001
TA	*The Tombs of Atuan*	1971
TD	*The Dispossessed: An Ambiguous Utopia*	1974
TE	*Tales from Earthsea*	2001
Teh	*Tehanu*	1990
Tel	*The Telling*	2000
WEa	*A Wizard of Earthsea*	1968
WM	*The Wave in the Mind* (essays)	2004
WTQ	*The Wind's Twelve Quarters* (stories)	1975
WWF	*The Word for World Is Forest*	1972; book 1976

The dissertation combines three procedures, and keeps them distinct. *Source genealogy* identifies named and demonstrable sources—Le Guin's own attributions in headnotes, introductions, essays, and translations—and tracks their transformation in the fiction. *Structural reconstruction* abstracts recurrent figures (wall, bag, hand, name, return) into a conceptual grammar whose consistency can be tested across genres and five decades. *Convergent reading* sets the corpus beside texts Le Guin did not demonstrably use, not as claims of influence but as instruments that make the structure visible. Where a link is interpretive rather than documentary, it is marked as such; the burden of the thesis rests on the second procedure, which the first constrains and the third corroborates.

The Spear and the Bag

> *Le Guin's work is not a confluence of influences but a single counter-anthropology, and its master figure is the vessel rather than the weapon. The chapters that follow test that claim against the whole corpus; this introduction states the problem it solves, the hypothesis it advances, and the architecture in which it is argued.*

i. The Problem of the Plural Le Guin

Le Guin's critical reception has proceeded by partition. The Daoist reading, inaugurated by Douglas Barbour's account of "wholeness and balance" in the Hainish novels (1974) and extended by Elizabeth Cummins Cogell (1979) and Dena C. Bain (1980), recovered the yin–yang dialectic and the ethic of *wuwei*. Utopian criticism—Fredric Jameson's essay on "world-reduction" (1975), Darko Suvin's "parables of de-alienation" (1975), Tom Moylan's paradigm of the "critical utopia" (1986), and the volume edited by Laurence Davis and Peter Stillman (2005)—made *The Dispossessed* the exemplary utopia of its century. Feminist criticism moved from reservation about the generic masculine of Gethen and the misogyny of Roke (LeFanu 1988) toward the recognition that Le Guin's self-revision is itself a method (Cummins 1990; Attebery 2002). Most recently, multispecies and Anthropocene thought has adopted "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" as a manifesto for post-anthropocentric narrative (Haraway 2016; Tsing et al. 2017).

Each reading is correct within its jurisdiction. Together they produce an author who is an anthology of positions: Daoist in Earthsea, anarchist on Anarres, ethnographer in the Na Valley, feminist after the 1987 "Redux." What none explains is why the same handful of figures recurs in every jurisdiction and every decade: the wall that opens *The Dispossessed* and the wall of stones that confines the dead in *The Other Wind*; the bag of the 1986 essay and the double spiral turning about an open center in *Always Coming Home*; the true name entrusted rather than seized; the voyage whose truth is its return; and the hands—the left hand of darkness, the women's league called the Hand in "The Finder," the empty hands of Shevek. Recurrence across jurisdictions is the signature of a structure prior to them. This dissertation names that structure and reconstructs its logic.

ii. Projectile and Recipient

Latin furnishes the terms. *Proicere* (*pro* + *iacere*, "to throw forward") yields *projectile*, *project*, and *projection*; *recipere* (*re* + *capere*, "to take back") yields *receive*, *receptacle*, *reception*, and *recipe*. Classical usage adds a decisive juridical sense: *recipere* also means to take a thing upon oneself, to undertake, to guarantee. The recipient is therefore not only the one who receives but the one who answers for what it holds, an etymological fact that disposes in advance of the objection that receptivity is passivity.

The projectile is the master figure of the dominant Western anthropology. Prometheus ("forethought") steals fire and gives humankind the arts of making; the preface to Marx's doctoral dissertation (1841) enrolled him as the foremost saint and martyr of the philosophical calendar. Pico's *Oration* (1486) places Adam at the center of the world, uniquely free to fashion himself into whatever form he prefers. Bacon's *Novum Organum* (1620) programs the extension of human empire over nature; Locke's *Second Treatise* (1690, §27) grounds political order on the premise that every man "has a property in his own person." Sartre's 1946 lecture defines the human as first of all a *projet*, and *Being and Time* (1927) figures Dasein as thrown projection (*geworfener Entwurf*), a being doubly ballistic. Twentieth-century paleoanthropology lent the figure scientific dress: Raymond Dart's "killer ape," Robert Ardrey's *African Genesis* (1961), and the *Man the Hunter* volume (Lee and DeVore 1968) made the weapon the first tool and the hunt the matrix of cooperation, language, and the sexual division of labor. Kubrick's *2001* (1968), released the year *A Wizard of Earthsea* appeared, compressed the doctrine into a single cut in which a flung bone becomes an orbiting craft. Joseph Campbell's monomyth (1949) supplied its narrative form—departure, ordeal, return with the boon—and the founding text of science fiction supplied its moral: *Frankenstein* is subtitled *The Modern Prometheus* (1818), and its plot is the story of a maker who throws a creature into the world and refuses to hold it.

The recipient has an older and more scattered genealogy. *DDJ* 11 locates the use of the wheel, the vessel, and the room in their emptiness. Aristotle defines place by analogy with the vessel and calls the vessel a place that can be carried about (*Physics* IV.4, 212a). Plato's receptacle (*hypodochē*, the "nurse of becoming," *Timaeus* 49a) is the same figure feminized and degraded into formless matter. Hesiod's Epimetheus ("afterthought"), against his brother's warning, *receives* Pandora and her storage jar (*Works and Days* 60–105). Sally Slocum's "Woman the Gatherer," first presented in the early 1970s and published in 1975, argued that the earliest cultural devices were probably containers for gathered food and slings for infants; Elizabeth Fisher built on the argument (1979); Le Guin turned it into a poetics (1986), and Haraway into a program (2016). Even the century's preeminent philosopher of projection arrived, late and by way of China, at the vessel: Heidegger's lecture "The Thing" (1950) locates the essence of a jug in the void that holds and the outpouring that gives, a passage Reinhard May (1996) traced to *DDJ* 11.

The opposition is not between activity and passivity. The spear and the bag are both technologies, both made by hands. They differ in their relation to what they touch. The projectile acts at a distance and divides: it kills, claims, or reaches across a gap it maintains. The recipient acts in proximity and gathers: it holds what it touches, carries it, and must

eventually set it down or give it away. Table 1 sets the two anthropologies side by side; each row is argued in the chapter indicated.

TABLE 1 · PROJECTILE AND RECIPIENT ANTHROPOLOGIES

Dimension	Projectile anthropology	Recipient anthropology	Chapter
Primal technology	Spear, club, point	Bag, sling, net, pot	5
Mythic patron	Prometheus (forethought)	Epimetheus and Pandora's jar; Hundun	1, 8
Property	Self-ownership; *dominium*	Holding in trust; the gift	2
Names	Naming as seizure	Naming as entrustment; unnaming	4
The other	Appropriation, salvage	Reception, hospitality	3
Sex	Fixed essence or self-authored performance	Sex received in relation (kemmer)	5
Time	Arrow of progress; "hot" history	Return; "cold" duration; simultaneity	6
Death	Immortality as the kept self	Release; the dead set free	4
Narrative form	Quest and climax	Carrier bag; compendium; telling	5
Boundary	Wall	Membrane	2, 8
Ethical horizon	Conquest or exit	Carrying	7

iii. Thesis

The claim of this dissertation is that Le Guin's oeuvre, taken whole, constitutes a *recipient humanism*: an account of the human as the being whose characteristic acts are receiving, holding, carrying, and releasing, and whose characteristic failures are the corruptions of those acts into appropriation, hoarding, confinement, and abandonment. Its ethical kernel is the Daoist formula of *xuande*, generation without possession. Its three negative moments are *dispossession*, the refusal of property in things, persons, and ideas (Chapter 2); *unnaming*, the refusal of the name as an instrument of mastery (Chapter 4); and *de-heroization*, the refusal of the projectile narrative and of its existential limit, immortality as the self kept forever (Chapters 4 and 5). Its positive practice is holding without having.

Its paradigm boundary is not the absence of boundary. Le Guin is not a philosopher of boundlessness in the manner of the smooth space of Deleuze and Guattari (1980). She distinguishes two forms of enclosure: the wall, which holds *out*, and the bag or membrane, which holds *for*—for later, for others, for giving. The wall is the bag hardened, and every corruption of recipience is a hardening.

The claim has a normative edge. A recipient humanism is a humanism: it retains a specific human capacity, the making of vessels, promises, and stories, and it does not dissolve the human into flows or networks. But it is a humanism without sovereignty, since nothing it holds, the self included, is held as property. It is therefore distinct both from the liberal tradition that C. B. Macpherson (1962) diagnosed as possessive individualism and from those

posthumanisms that, in renouncing the sovereign subject, renounce the human altogether (Braidotti 2013).

iv. The Dissertation That Was Not Written

Le Guin was trained at Radcliffe (A.B. 1951) and Columbia (A.M. 1952) in French and Italian Renaissance literature, and she began a doctoral dissertation on the poet Jean Lemaire de Belges (c. 1473–c. 1525), abandoned after her marriage in Paris in 1953. It would be overreading to derive the oeuvre from an unfinished thesis, yet the coincidences are instructive. Lemaire's *Concorde des deux langages* (c. 1511) allegorizes accord between French and Tuscan; his *Épîtres de l'Amant vert* (1505) are letters written by a parrot, the second of which visits an afterlife of animals; his *Illustrations de Gaule et Singularitez de Troye* (1511–13) fabricates an antiquity for a living people. Concord between tongues, the speech of animals, and invented archaeology recur in the mature work as the triad of mother, father, and native tongue (Bryn Mawr Commencement Address, 1986), the therolinguistics of "The Author of the Acacia Seeds" (1974), and the archaeology of the future that is *Always Coming Home*.

More decisive is the tradition Lemaire belongs to, the vernacular humanism that runs from Dante to the Pléiade. *De vulgari eloquentia* (I.i.2) defines the vernacular as the speech that, imitating the nurse and without any rule, we *receive*: *sine omni regula nutricem imitantes accipimus*. Du Bellay's *Deffence et illustration de la langue françoyse* (1549) defends that received tongue against the Latin of the schools. The same tradition contains Montaigne's "Des cannibales" (1580), a founding text of cultural relativism three centuries before Boas, and Rabelais's Abbey of Thélème (*Gargantua*, 1534), a community of women and men built without walls, whose only rule is to do as one wills. The recipient humanism reconstructed here is therefore not an anti-humanism imported from elsewhere. It is the recovery of a submerged strand within humanism itself: the humanism of the received tongue, against the humanism of the sovereign self.

v. Architecture

Part One, *Genealogies*, reconstructs the three source-traditions—Daoism (Chapter 1), anarchism (Chapter 2), and anthropology (Chapter 3)—each read for its contribution to the recipient figure and for the corruption it taught Le Guin to fear. Part Two, *Transvaluations*, follows the figure into three domains where it overturns an inherited hierarchy: the name, the shadow, and death in Earthsea (Chapter 4); sex, the receptacle, and narrative form (Chapter 5); and time, ecology, and the politics of not-doing (Chapter 6). Part Three, *Limits and Synthesis*, confronts the figure with the strongest objections to it, the problem of violence and the charge of quietism focused in "Omelas" (Chapter 7), before formalizing recipient humanism and differentiating it from its nearest neighbors (Chapter 8). The Conclusion returns to the image with which *The Dispossessed* ends: hands that are empty, and for that reason able to hold.

PART ONE

Genealogies



CHAPTER 1

The Valley Spirit

Laozi, Zhuangzi, and the Ontology of the Useful Void

CHAPTER 2

The Unbuilt Wall

Anarchism, Dispossession, and the Odonian Membrane

CHAPTER 3

The Superorganic and the Last Yahi

Anthropology and the Primal Scene of Dispossession

1

CHAPTER ONE

The Valley Spirit: Laozi, Zhuangzi, and the Ontology of the Useful Void

> *Le Guin's Daoism is the ontological floor of her work rather than its ornament, and its decisive gift is a concept of emptiness as capacity joined to an ethic of generation without possession. This chapter reconstructs both, then shows that the selectivity of her Daoism is itself governed by the recipient principle it teaches.*

1.1 Transmission and Reception

Le Guin met the *Daodejing* in adolescence, in her father's copy of the translation Paul Carus published through Open Court in 1898, prepared with the assistance of the young D. T. Suzuki. She returned to it across her life, and in 1997 published *Lao Tzu: Tao Te Ching*, made with the collaboration of the sinologist J. P. Seaton. She did not read Chinese and called the book a rendition rather than a translation. Her stated governing choices were two: to release the text from its address to rulers, and to release its sage from the masculine pronoun.

The first choice is historically contestable. A. C. Graham (1989) and Hans-Georg Moeller (2006) read the *Daodejing* as a work of statecraft addressed to a sage-ruler, its quietism a technique of government. Le Guin's version is better described as a reception in the strict sense this dissertation gives the word: she takes up the vessel of the text and refills it, dispossessing the ruler of his manual and redistributing its counsel to anyone. The anarchist act is performed on the translation before it appears in the fiction.

A caution belongs here. The "philosophical Taoism" of the postwar West—Alan Watts's *The Way of Zen* (1957), Fritjof Capra's *The Tao of Physics* (1975), Benjamin Hoff's *The Tao of Pooh* (1982)—is a construction that brackets *Daojiao*, the liturgical, alchemical, and institutional religion, and Said's *Orientalism* (1978) teaches suspicion of such constructions. Le Guin's Daoism shares their selectivity. Its principle of selection, however, is legible, and §1.7 argues that it is itself recipient.

1.2 *Wu* as Use: The Hub, the Vessel, the Room

DDJ 11 states the ontology in three images. Thirty spokes share one hub: where there is nothing, there is the use of the cart. Clay is kneaded to make a vessel: where there is nothing, there is the use of the vessel. Doors and windows are cut to make a room: where there is nothing, there is the use of the room. Therefore what is there serves as benefit; what is not there serves as use.

The three images distribute Le Guin's corpus. The vessel becomes the carrier bag (Chapter 5). The room becomes the household as the unit of polity: the Houses of the Kesh, the domiciles of Anarres, the Hearths of Gethen. The wheel becomes the hinge of return (§1.6) and the turning year. Throughout, the void is not lack but the condition of function. Le Guin's characteristic sentence about a thing is a sentence about what it makes room for.

Gethen's two religions turn the ontology into politics. The Handdara has no clergy, hierarchy, vows, or creed; it cultivates ignorance as a discipline, and its Foretellers of Otherhord answer questions chiefly to demonstrate, as the Weaver Faxe explains, the uselessness of knowing the answer to the wrong question (*LHD* ch. 5). Yomesh, the state cult of Orgoreyn, descends from Meshe, who saw all things at once and without shadow. Le Guin binds the two epistemologies to two regimes. Yomesh plenitude belongs to Orgoreyn's administered totality, with its Commensals, its secret police, and its "Voluntary Farms" that are camps; Handdara emptiness belongs to the looser, quarrelsome, unregimented order of Karhide. The regime that wants to see everything must fill every space.

The novel's title condenses the point. In Tormer's Lay, light is the left hand of darkness and darkness the right hand of light: not two substances at war but two hands of one body. On the Gobrin Ice, Genly Ai draws for Estraven the figure of yin and yang, names its paired opposites down to female and male, and tells him that the figure is himself, both and one (*LHD*, the Ice chapters). The same passage of the journey records the two travelers setting aside *shifgrethor*—prestige, face, the pride-relation, a word the novel derives from an old word for shadow—in favor of mindspeech. Le Guin's figure of complementarity is bimanual. The hands are the body's organs of holding, and a body holds with two.

1.3 *Xuande*: Generation without Possession

The ethical kernel of the corpus is a formula that recurs in *DDJ* 10 and 51, with a variant in chapter 2: 生而不有，為而不恃，長而不宰，是謂玄德. To give birth without possessing, to act without presuming upon it, to raise without ruling: this is called mysterious virtue. The vocabulary is generative: *sheng* (to bear), *xu* (畜, to rear), *zhang* (長, to raise). The text's figure for the Way is repeatedly maternal: the named is the mother of the myriad things (ch. 1); the Way may be taken as the mother of the world (chs. 25, 52). *Xuande* articulates non-possession in a maternal grammar, and it does so against the juridical grammars that would define Western property: Roman *patria potestas*, under which a father held power of life and death over his children, and *dominium*, an owner's absolute right in a thing.

At this point Daoism meets the other source-traditions. Proudhon's *Qu'est-ce que la propriété?* (1840) answers that property is theft. Engels's *Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884) ties the overthrow of mother-right, which he called the world-historical defeat of the female sex, to the rise of private property and the patrilineal

inheritance it requires. *Xuande* is their anticipatory synthesis: what one generates, one does not own, and the refusal to own what one generates strikes patriarchy at its root. *DDJ* 81 supplies the economics. The sage does not accumulate; having done for others, she has more; having given to others, she is richer. This is the logic of the gift two millennia before Mauss (1925) and Hyde (1983).

The fictions instantiate the formula with precision. Ogion gives Ged his true name and his freedom and retains neither (*WEa* chs. 1–2). Shevek gives his General Temporal Theory to every world at once rather than let any state own it (*TD* ch. 12). The Kesh bind wealth to giving (*ACH*). Tenar raises the burned child Therru without ruling her and finally releases her to the dragons (*Teh*; *OW*). The Ekumen acts without presuming: its envoy arrives alone and waits to be invited (*LHD*). *Xuande* is the thread that sews the anarchist, the feminist, and the ethnographic Le Guin into one garment.

1.4 *Wuwei*, the Uncarved Block, and the Potter's Wheel of Heaven

The Lathe of Heaven (1971) is the corpus's most systematic dramatization of *wuwei*. George Orr's dreams alter reality retroactively. The psychiatrist William Haber, equipped with an "Augmentor," steers those dreams toward improving the world, and each improvement is a catastrophe: overpopulation is solved by plague, racial hatred by a universal gray skin, war by an alien invasion that unites humanity against a common enemy, a device Alan Moore's *Watchmen* would make famous fifteen years later. Haber is the projectile humanist in clinical dress, benevolent and utilitarian, an heir of Bacon's *New Atlantis* and Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948). His name sounds, as an interpretive gloss rather than a documented intention, the Latin *habere* and Spanish *haber*: to have. Orr, whose tests place him at the exact median of every scale, is the novel's sage, the one who does not force. The Aldebaranian aliens, for whom dreaming is a mode of action, are his natural allies.

The title comes from James Legge's *Zhuangzi* (1891, ch. 23): understanding that stops at what it cannot understand is the highest attainment, and those who cannot stop there will be destroyed "on the lathe of Heaven." The Chinese term is *tianjun* (天鈞), which also appears in chapter 2, where the sage harmonizes "this" and "that" and rests in *tianjun*. Watson renders it "Heaven the Equalizer" (1968); Graham, "the potter's wheel of Heaven" (1981). *Jun* (鈞) is the potter's wheel, the turning table on which clay is thrown into vessels. Legge's lathe, which shapes material by cutting it away against a fixed tool, substitutes subtraction for hollowing, the machine shop for the pottery—a rendering now generally regarded as a mistranslation.

The mistranslation enacts the novel's argument in miniature. Haber treats the world as stock for a lathe; the Daoist cosmos is a wheel that makes vessels. *DDJ* 29 names the stakes: the world is a numinous vessel (*shenqi* 神器) that cannot be worked upon; whoever works on it ruins it, and whoever grasps it loses it. The verb of ruin (*bai* 敗) is the same in that chapter and in Zhuangzi's sentence about *tianjun*. Orr, meanwhile, is *pu* (樸), the uncarved block (*DDJ* 28, 32), the very material the lathe would turn into a product.

1.5 Hundun, or the Sack That Was Given a Face

The Inner Chapters close with a fable (ZZ 7). Shu and Hu, emperors of the southern and northern seas, are entertained by Hundun, emperor of the center. Wishing to repay his kindness, they observe that every person has seven openings for seeing, hearing, eating, and breathing, whereas Hundun has none. They bore one opening a day, and on the seventh day Hundun dies. The *Shanhaijing* describes a god of the same lineage, Dijiang (帝江), as shaped like a yellow sack, red as cinnabar fire, with six legs and four wings, faceless (*hundun wu mianmu*), and knowing how to sing and dance (Girardot 1983). The primordial being of Daoist myth is a faceless bag that sings.

Two consequences follow. First, the fable is the archetype of the lethal improvement that recurs throughout Le Guin: Haber's dreams; the Terran loggers of WWF; the first Ekumenical contact with Aka, which sets off the Corporation's "March to the Stars" and its war on the old ways (*Tel*). In each case a benefactor bores a face into a being that lived by facelessness, and the gift kills. Second, the carrier bag has a cosmogonic ancestor. Before the face—before identity, the gaze, and the sense-organs as instruments of taking-in-for-oneself—there is the sack that holds and sings. There is no evidence that Le Guin read Girardot; the convergence is offered as corroboration, not source.

Zhuangzi supplies a companion image. Huizi complains that a giant gourd grown from a royal seed is useless, too weak to hold water and too flat for a dipper, and he smashes it. Zhuangzi answers that he might have lashed it into a great float and gone drifting on the rivers and lakes (ZZ 1). The vessel that fails as a utility becomes a vehicle of free wandering (*xiaoyao you*). The same chapter and chapter 4 tell of trees that live out their years because their wood is useless to the carpenter. Le Guin's defense of fantasy against the American demand for utility in "Why Are Americans Afraid of Dragons?" (1974) is Zhuangzian; so, inversely, is the fate of Athshe in WWF, whose forests die because their timber is useful to a deforested Earth.

1.6 Reversal and Return

Reversal is the movement of the Way, and weakness its use (DDJ 40); the myriad things flourish and each returns to its root, and returning to the root is called stillness (DDJ 16). Le Guin's plots move by return rather than progress. *The Dispossessed* alternates chapters set on Urras in the present with chapters set on Anarres in the past until the two lines meet, so that the final chapter closes the circle the first opened. Its physics makes the structure a theorem: Shevek's General Temporal Theory unifies Sequency, time as arrow, and Simultaneity, time as cycle and whole. Its maxim is that true journey is return, glossed by a meditation on Heraclitus's river and on Thomas Wolfe's dictum that you can't go home again, which concludes that you can, so long as you understand home as a place where you have never been. Ged's voyages end in returns to Gont. Genly Ai's report ends at Estraven's hearth, with his father and his child. *Always Coming Home* takes a progressive participle for its title: a homecoming that never completes.

The contrast with Homeric *nostos* is exact. Odysseus's return is a repossession: he reclaims house, wife, and goods by slaughtering the suitors and hanging the women of the household who consorted with them (*Odyssey* 22). Le Guin's returns restore nothing; they

transform both the returner and the home. They are the Daoist *fu* (復) stripped of Homeric property. Here a second convergence comes into view. The last sentence of Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) names *Heimat* as something that shines into everyone's childhood and where no one has yet been. Shevek's home and Bloch's *Heimat* are the same utopian place: a return to somewhere never yet inhabited.

1.7 What Le Guin Did Not Take

Religious Daoism sought deathlessness: the cult of the *xian* immortals, outer and inner alchemy, techniques for preserving the body beyond its term. Le Guin took none of it. Her Daoism is Zhuangzi's acceptance of transformation. When his wife dies, Zhuangzi is found drumming on a basin and singing; he explains that her life arose from the changes of *qi* and has returned into them, as the seasons turn (ZZ 18). That anecdote is *The Other Wind* in a single scene (Chapter 4).

The selection is not arbitrary. Le Guin received from the tradition what could be held without being hoarded, and declined what aimed to keep the self forever. *The Telling* (2000) makes the problem of reception its subject. Le Guin said it was prompted by learning of the suppression of Daoism during the Cultural Revolution, and its Terran Observer, Sutty, discovers that the Akan Telling is not a creed but a vast, unsystematic practice of story, exercise, healing, and record, which a foreigner may receive but cannot own (*Tel*). The chapter's yield can be stated briefly. From Laozi, Le Guin takes the void as capacity, the ethic of *xuande*, and the movement of return. From Zhuangzi, she takes the critique of benevolent intervention, the potter's wheel that makes vessels, and the release of the dead.

2

CHAPTER TWO

The Unbuilt Wall: Anarchism, Dispossession, and the Odonian Membrane

> *Le Guin's anarchism is a theory of the boundary: it does not abolish enclosure but distinguishes the wall that holds out from the membrane that holds for. The Dispossessed is the corpus's most rigorous test of whether a society can keep the second from hardening into the first, and its answer is a qualified, continuously renewed yes.*

2.1 Lineage: Anarchism "Prefigured in Early Taoist Thought"

Le Guin stated her sources in the headnote to "The Day Before the Revolution" (1974; WTQ). Odonianism is anarchism: not the terrorism that borrows the name, nor the social-Darwinist libertarianism of the economic right, but the anarchism "prefigured in early Taoist thought" and expounded by Shelley, Kropotkin, Goldman, and Goodman. The story is dedicated to the memory of Paul Goodman, who had died in 1972.

The lineage is pacifist and constructive. William Godwin's *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice* (1793) argued that government corrupts the private judgment it claims to protect. Shelley, Godwin's son-in-law, wrote the anarchist lyric drama of the age; in *Prometheus Unbound* (1820) the Titan triumphs not by theft but by revoking his own curse, a Promethean renunciation of the projectile to which Chapter 8 returns. Kropotkin's *Mutual Aid* (1902) answered T. H. Huxley's "The Struggle for Existence" (1888) with evidence from Siberian fieldwork and from the history of guilds, villages, and communes that cooperation is a factor of evolution as real as competition. Goldman's *Anarchism and Other Essays* (1910) bound anarchism to free love, contraception, and the critique of marriage as property.

Two further figures, unnamed in the headnote, sharpen the inheritance. Gustav Landauer (1910) defined the state not as a thing to be seized but as a relationship among human beings, destroyed only by entering into other relationships, an exact prefiguration of Odo's doctrine that the revolution can be neither bought nor made, only lived, in the individual spirit or nowhere (TD). Colin Ward's *Anarchy in Action* (1973), published the year before *The Dispossessed*, described anarchy as already present in everyday cooperation, a seed beneath

the snow, an image a reader of Gethen may savor. Goodman's *Communitas* (1947, with Percival Goodman) and his decentralist essays supplied the practical imagination of small, federated, functional communities.

Odo herself is the crucial innovation. The anarchist tradition is a genealogy of fathers: Godwin, Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin. Le Guin gives Anarres a mother. "The Day Before the Revolution" follows Laia Asieo Odo in old age, after a stroke, in the house where the movement keeps her, irritable at being made a monument, on the eve of the uprising that will bear her name. The story applies *xuande* to a political movement: Odo generates a revolution she refuses to own.

2.2 Possessive Individualism and Its Counter-Grammar

Macpherson (1962) identified the presupposition uniting Hobbes, Harrington, and Locke: the individual as proprietor of his own person and capacities, owing nothing to society for them. Locke's §27 is its charter. Le Guin's counter-grammar is literal. Pravic, the constructed language of Anarres, discourages the possessive: a child is taught to speak of the handkerchief she uses rather than of *her* handkerchief, and the vocabulary of moral reproach includes "egoizing" and "propertarian" (*TD*). The device presupposes the Sapir–Whorf hypothesis of linguistic relativity, whose genealogy runs close to home: Edward Sapir, Kroeber's colleague, worked with Ishi on the Yahi language in the Kroeber museum in 1915 (Chapter 3). The novel does not claim that grammar determines thought. It shows a society using grammar as one scaffold of a non-possessive ethic, and then shows the scaffold failing.

The title answers a possessed book. Constance Garnett's 1916 English version of Dostoevsky's *Besy*, his anti-revolutionary novel of nihilist conspiracy, was titled *The Possessed*. Le Guin loved Dostoevsky as a young reader, as her headnote to "Omelas" acknowledges, and her title inverts his. Where Dostoevsky's revolutionaries are possessed, as by demons, hers are dispossessed: of property, of a homeland (they are exiles on a moon), and of the demonic possession Dostoevsky saw in revolution. The inversion's intent cannot be documented, but it is hard to read as accidental. The subtitle, *An Ambiguous Utopia*, names what the dispossession costs.

2.3 An Anarchism of Scarcity

Anarres is a dry moon. Its Odonian settlers, who left Urras in a negotiated secession nearly two centuries before the novel's present, live under the permanent threat of famine; the drought of Shevek's young adulthood cuts rations and scatters workers to emergency postings (*TD*). Le Guin sets her anarchism in scarcity deliberately, removing the standard objection that statelessness requires abundance.

The contrast is instructive. Murray Bookchin's *Post-Scarcity Anarchism* (1971) made technological abundance the precondition of freedom; Iain M. Banks's Culture novels (from 1987) imagine an anarchism of superabundance managed by benevolent machine Minds. Le Guin's wager is harder and more Daoist: a society that holds little and gives it away. Scarcity is the stress test of the membrane, because in famine holding becomes hoarding, and the novel shows both.

2.4 The Tyranny of the Social Conscience

The utopia's ambiguity is anatomized with unusual candor. Sabul, a senior physicist, appropriates Shevek's work, controls its publication, and exercises a power no institution formally grants him. Bedap names the disease: the social conscience has curdled into public opinion, which governs as surely as any law; innovation is resented as egoizing; labor postings become instruments of punishment; the revolution has ossified into custom (*TD*).

The diagnosis anticipates what Jo Freeman, writing of the women's movement, called "The Tyranny of Structurelessness" (1970/1972): where no formal structure exists, informal elites rule without accountability. It also descends from Mill's *On Liberty* (1859), whose subject is the tyranny of the majority exercised through opinion rather than law. Shevek and his allies found the Syndicate of Initiative to print and broadcast what the consensus suppresses, and Shevek's voyage to Urras is itself one of its acts: Odo's permanent revolution re-enacted against Odonianism.

The point for this dissertation is structural. Every pathology of Anarres is a hardening: of opinion into law, of informal influence into ownership of a field (Sabul "owns" physics while owning nothing), of the commune's boundary into a wall. The utopia is ambiguous because its membrane is alive, and what lives can calcify.

2.5 Wall and Membrane

The novel opens on a wall, the low boundary around the spaceport where Urrasti ships may land, which, the narrator observes, did not look important (*TD* ch. 1). Its ambiguity is topological: which side is inside depends on where one stands, so that the wall either encloses the universe and leaves Anarres outside, or encloses Anarres and leaves the universe outside. Shevek's declared project is to unbuild walls. The Renaissance tradition in which Le Guin was trained had already made the same diagnosis. Gargantua orders that the Abbey of Thélème be built with no wall around it, since, as Rabelais's pun has it, where there is wall (*mur*) before and behind there is murmuring, envy, and conspiracy (*Gargantua* ch. 52).

Yet Anarres is not wall-less; it is a membrane-society. Odo's major treatise, as the novel reports it, is called *Analogy*: the analogy of the social to the organic, the cell, and the organism, in the line of Kropotkin's biology. A cell has a boundary; without one there is no cell. What distinguishes a membrane from a wall is selective permeability. It holds what the cell needs, passes what it must exchange, and lives by the traffic. The Production and Distribution Coordination is accordingly a nervous system rather than a government, a computing membrane that coordinates without commanding. Odonian partnership is a promise rather than an institution (§2.7).

Biology supplies the decisive corroboration. Lynn Margulis's theory of endosymbiosis, first set out in "On the Origin of Mitosing Cells" (published under the name Sagan, 1967), holds that the eukaryotic cell arose when one organism took another into itself and, instead of digesting it, kept it: the mitochondrion is a guest that became an organ. Complex life began with holding without consuming. This is not Le Guin's source; it is the biological form of her political argument, and Chapter 8 returns to it. Le Guin distinguishes not openness from closure but two closures. The question the novel puts to every Anarresti practice is whether it is still a membrane or has become a wall.

2.6 The Gift of the Theory

Shevek's physics is the novel's conceptual center. Physics on Urras divides into Sequency, time as linear succession, and Simultaneity, time as co-presence; Shevek's General Temporal Theory unifies them. The opposition maps onto McTaggart's A-series and B-series (1908) and onto the twentieth-century dispute between becoming and the block universe; it also maps onto the Daoist reconciliation of change and constancy. Its practical consequence is the ansible, instantaneous communication across interstellar distance, the technology that makes the Ekumen possible (Chapter 6).

The climax is an act of dispossession. The government of A-Io seeks to own the theory as an instrument of advantage. Shevek, sheltered in the Terran embassy, gives it to the Terran ambassador Keng and the Hainish to broadcast to all worlds at once, so that no one can own it (*TD* ch. 12). The gift is the anarchist answer to intellectual property, a knowledge commons avant la lettre, before Elinor Ostrom (1990) theorized commons governance and before the free-software movement made the gesture routine. It is also *xuande*. Shevek generates the theory and refuses to possess it, and the theory's content, time held as a whole rather than spent as a line, is the temporal form of holding.

2.7 Promise and Forgiveness: Arendt's Two Faculties

Hannah Arendt closes the chapter on action in *The Human Condition* (1958) by naming two faculties that redeem action from its predicaments. Against irreversibility, the fact that we cannot undo what we have done, stands the power to forgive. Against unpredictability, the fact that we cannot know what will follow from what we do, stands the power to make and keep promises. Le Guin wrote a book about each.

The Dispossessed is a book of promises. Shevek and Takver's partnership is not a legal institution but a bond freely chosen and continually renewed, and its fidelity across four years of separation by famine postings is the novel's emotional spine (*TD*). *Four Ways to Forgiveness* (1995) is a book of releases: in the aftermath of slavery on Werel and Yeowe, its four novellas examine what forgiveness can and cannot do between owners and the owned, colonizers and colonized, and between liberated men and the women their liberation left unfree (Chapter 7).

The mapping completes the recipient grammar. A promise is a holding: it takes the future into one's hands and answers for it, which is *recipere* in its juridical sense. Forgiveness is a release: it opens the hand on the past. The open hand that holds and lets go is the anthropological form of Arendt's two faculties. Arendt's other distinction, between labor, work, and action, with its ranking of the durable world of *homo faber* above the perishable round of the *animal laborans* whose sphere was the household, is contested in Chapter 5, where the carrier bag reveals the perishable as the matrix of story. Here it is enough that the two faculties Arendt thought most political are, in Le Guin, the two movements of one hand.

3

CHAPTER THREE

The Superorganic and the Last Yahi: Anthropology and the Primal Scene of Dispossession

> *Le Guin inherited from Boasian anthropology both a method of reception, the discipline of receiving another world on its own terms, and that method's shadow, the museum that keeps what was never given. The Hainish cycle and Always Coming Home are her attempts to practice the first while confessing the second.*

3.1 Boas, Kroeber, and the Superorganic

Alfred Louis Kroeber (1876–1960) received Columbia's first doctorate in anthropology under Franz Boas in 1901 and built the department and museum of anthropology at the University of California. The Boasian program—cultural relativism, historical particularism, the refusal to rank cultures on an evolutionary ladder—has a humanist ancestor in Montaigne's remark that each people calls barbarous whatever is not its own custom ("Des cannibales," 1580). Kroeber's distinctive theoretical contribution, "The Superorganic" (1917), argued that culture is a level of reality irreducible to biology or individual psychology: a pattern that outlasts and shapes its bearers. His *Handbook of the Indians of California* (1925) remains a monument of salvage ethnography, and Theodora Kroeber's *Ishi in Two Worlds* (1961) became the most widely read work of American anthropology.

Le Guin grew up among anthropologists and their interlocutors, in the Berkeley house and at Kishamish, the family's summer place in the Napa Valley, where Native visitors such as the Yurok Robert Spott and the Tohono O'odham Juan Dolores came, as she recalled in "Indian Uncles" (WM). From this inheritance she took three things: the conviction that cultures are wholes with their own logic, transposed into the world-building of the Hainish cycle; the method of participant observation, which is reception institutionalized; and the documentary form of field notes, myths, and testimony that structures *The Left Hand of Darkness* and *Always Coming Home*. She also took its guilt.

3.2 Ishi: The Museum as Container

In August 1911 a starving man was found near Oroville, California. He was the last survivor of the Yahi, a people destroyed in what historians now name the California genocide (Madley 2016). The state of California funded militia campaigns against Native Californians from 1851, the year Governor Peter Burnett told the legislature to expect a war of extermination until the Indian race became extinct. In the Yahi homeland along Mill and Deer Creeks, settler vigilantes and self-styled Indian hunters, Robert Anderson and Hi Good among them, massacred Yahi families through the 1860s, at Three Knolls in 1865 among other places, and around 1871 a party of cattlemen killed some thirty Yahi at Kingsley Cave (T. Kroeber 1961). Ishi and a handful of survivors hid in the canyons for some forty years. Kroeber brought him to the university's museum in San Francisco, where he lived, worked as the museum's assistant janitor, was put on view on Sunday afternoons to crowds who watched him flake arrowheads and make fire, as the last "wild" Indian the newspapers had made of him, and was given the name Ishi, a Yahi word for "man," since he did not speak his own name. In 1915 Edward Sapir came to record his language. Ishi died of tuberculosis in March 1916. Kroeber, then in New York, had written asking that no autopsy be performed and that, if anyone spoke of the interests of science, science could go to hell. University physicians performed one anyway and removed the brain. Kroeber, on his return, offered it to the physical anthropologist Aleš Hrdlička and shipped it to the Smithsonian, where it remained until Orin Starn traced it in 1999 (Starn 2004). In 2000 it was repatriated to the Redding Rancheria and the Pit River Tribe and buried with Ishi's ashes in an undisclosed place. Le Guin's brothers Karl and Clifton Kroeber co-edited *Ishi in Three Centuries* (2003).

The episode is the primal scene of the recipient's corruption. A museum is an institution of reception: it receives, holds, keeps. When its holding was not given, and when it refuses to let what it holds perish or return, reception becomes appropriation and the container becomes a collection. James Clifford (1986, 1988) analyzed this "salvage paradigm" as a founding allegory of anthropology, in which the vanishing other must be saved by being kept. Ishi was received with kindness, named, housed, studied, and exhibited; then a part of his body was kept against his people's ways and against his friend's request.

The dissertation does not claim that the fiction is a confession of family history. It claims something more structural: that the corpus distinguishes the trust-archive from the trophy-archive with a precision only an heir of the salvage tradition would need, and that the distinction becomes, in *The Other Wind*, the release of the dead from a walled collection (Chapter 4).

3.3 The Ekumen: To Be Received

The Hainish cycle turns first contact into an ethics. Hain seeded the humanoid worlds in deep prehistory; the Ekumen, successor to the League of All Worlds, is an association that neither conquers nor governs. Its envoy to Gethen comes alone and unarmed and waits to be invited, because, as Genly Ai explains, one alien is a curiosity while two would be an invasion (*LHD*). The Ekumen's method is to be received.

Kant stated the principle at the threshold of modern cosmopolitanism. The third definitive article of *Perpetual Peace* (1795) limits cosmopolitan right to the conditions of

universal hospitality: a stranger's right not to be treated with hostility on arrival, a right to visit but not to settle. Kant condemns in the same passage the inhospitable conduct of the commercial states that, under cover of visiting, conquered the Americas, Africa, and the East Indies. The Ekumen is Kant's visitor; the Terran logging colony of *The Word for World Is Forest* is Kant's commercial conqueror. Derrida's distinction between conditional and unconditional hospitality (1997) clarifies the protocol further: the envoy offers himself without condition, while the planet's acceptance remains free. Levinas (1961) grounded the ethics of welcome in the face of the other; Le Guin grounds it in the hand.

The Ekumen is not innocent. Its Observers in *The Telling* discover that an earlier contact set off Aka's modernizing frenzy (Chapter 1), and its Hainish founders are ancient and weary, burdened by having already tried everything. The ethics of reception guarantees nothing. It is a discipline of minimizing the face one bores into Hundun.

3.4 Athshe: The Contamination of Killing

The Word for World Is Forest (1972; Hugo Award, 1973) is the corpus's anticolonial novel, written, Le Guin later said, in anger during the American war in Vietnam. Terrans clear-cut the forests of Athshe and enslave its small, green-furred people, whom they call "creechies," creatures: a name that is itself a seizure (Chapter 4). The Athsheans have no war. Their culture is organized around disciplined dreaming, in which world-time and dream-time are equally real, a conception commonly traced to Kilton Stewart's since-discredited account of Senoi dream practice. Captain Davidson, whose rape of Selver's wife ends in her death, is the projectile humanist without disguise. Raj Lyubov, the Terran specialist in Athshean culture, whose name means "love," is the receiver: he learns the language, befriends Selver, and dies in the uprising he could not prevent.

Selver becomes a *sha'ab*, a god or translator. He brings his people a new thing, killing. His fighters kill some two hundred men at the Smith Camp logging station, then storm Centralville, the colony's headquarters, where many more Terrans die, Lyubov among them; Davidson answers with reprisal raids that burn Athshean towns and kill their people. When the Athsheans finally take Davidson, Selver will not kill him, and leaves him on Dump Island, ground the loggers had stripped bare. The novel neither condemns the revolt nor celebrates it. Selver knows that what has been brought into the Athshean world cannot be taken out of it again; killing, once learned, is carried forward. The verb is decisive. Le Guin does not ask only whether anticolonial violence is justified, the question on which Fanon (1961) and Gandhi stand opposed and to which Chapter 7 returns. She asks what it is to carry it. The recipient's burden includes what one did not choose to receive.

3.5 *Always Coming Home* and the Reflexive Turn

Always Coming Home (1985) is a fictional ethnography of the Kesh, a people who may come to live, long after our industrial civilization, in the Valley of the Na: the Napa Valley of Le Guin's summers. It contains narratives, poems, plays, maps, an alphabet, a glossary, notes on the Houses of Earth and Sky and their dances, and a recording of music composed by Todd Barton. The Kesh's sacred figure is the *heyiya-if*, a hinge whose two arms turn about an open center. They are a "cold" society in Lévi-Strauss's sense (Chapter 6) and, in Pierre Clastres's phrase, a society against the state (1974). Their neighbors, the Condor People, are militarist, patriarchal, monotheist, and expansionist, and the book's central narrative—the life of Stone Telling, daughter of a Kesh mother and a Condor father—traces her captivity among them and her return. The Kesh bind wealth to giving, so that to be rich is to give much: the logic of the potlatch, which Boas observed on the Northwest Coast and Mauss theorized (1925), without its competitive edge.

The book contains its own ethnographer's doubt. Interleaved sections bearing the name Pandora record the author-figure's worry about what she is doing: fabricating a people, speaking for them, idealizing them. *Always Coming Home* appeared in 1985; *Writing Culture: The Poetics and Politics of Ethnography* (Clifford and Marcus 1986) appeared the next year. The reflexive turn in anthropology and Le Guin's novel arrive together, and the daughter of the Boasian discipline wrote its crisis of representation from inside, as fiction. The name of her doubting persona is exact. Pandora is the woman who brings the jar (Chapter 8). And the Kesh escape the salvage paradigm by a temporal inversion: they are not a vanishing people saved by a collector but a people not yet existing, received from the future.

The objection must be recorded. The Kesh can be read as a settler fantasy of indigeneity, and the book borrows forms, though not content, from Californian Native cultures. Le Guin's defense is internal: the Kesh are not Indians, the book is explicit about its fabrication, and the Pandora sections expose the authorial hand. The defense is partial. *Always Coming Home* is the corpus's most self-aware recipient text and its most exposed: it holds what it did not originate, and knows it.

3.6 *The Telling* and *Voices*: Orality, Legibility, and the Carried Archive

Two late fictions make the distinction between the trust-archive and the trophy-archive explicit. In *The Telling*, the Corporation State of Aka, pursuing its March to the Stars, has burned the old books and outlawed the *maz*, the tellers; Sutty finds the surviving texts hidden in a mountain library kept by people who preserve them by continuing to read, copy, and tell. In *Voices* (2006), the city of Ansul, occupied by the Alds, fire-worshipping enemies of books, keeps its library hidden in the house of its Oracle, where the young Memer learns in secret to read. In both, the archive is not a collection but a carried thing: held in trust under threat, kept alive by use, and given away.

James C. Scott supplies the political frame. *Seeing Like a State* (1998) shows that high-modernist states require legibility—simplified, standardized, centrally readable populations—and destroy the local, practical knowledge (*mētis*) on which life depends. The Corporation of Aka is a state that sees; the Telling is *mētis*. Scott's *The Art of Not Being Governed* (2009) argues that orality and mobility were, for the upland peoples of Southeast

Asia, strategies of escape from the state's gaze; the wandering, oral *maz* are such people. *The Telling* thus restates the opposition of Yomesh and Handdara (Chapter 1) as an opposition of archives. The state's archive is a collection that sees. The people's archive is a bag that is carried.

The chapter's yield is a criterion. From anthropology Le Guin took reception as method, culture as a superorganic whole, and the documentary form; from its history she took the knowledge that reception decays into collection. Her fictions distinguish the two by a single test: whether what is held can be given back, given away, or allowed to perish.

PART TWO

Transvaluations



CHAPTER 4

The Name, the Shadow, and the Dry Land

Earthsea as a Theory of Self-Dispossession

CHAPTER 5

Kemmer and the Carrier Bag

Gender, the Receptacle, and Feminist Poetics

CHAPTER 6

Cold Utopia

Time, Ecology, and the Politics of Not-Doing

4

CHAPTER FOUR

The Name, the Shadow, and the Dry Land: Earthsea as a Theory of Self-Dispossession

Across six books and thirty-three years, Earthsea moves from the mastery of names to the release of the dead, and the movement is one argument: the last possession to be surrendered is the self. Read in sequence, the cycle enacts all three negative moments of recipient humanism, and its final novel extends the wall to the scale of death.

4.1 Adamic Speech and the Name as Gift

Earthsea's magic rests on the Old Speech, the Language of the Making, in which a thing's true name is the thing; Segoy raised the islands from the sea by speaking their names (*WEa*). This is Adamic language in Walter Benjamin's sense ("On Language as Such and on the Language of Man," 1916): a language in which name and being coincide, and in which human naming translates the mute language of things into the language of names. For Benjamin the Fall turns naming into judgment and abstraction, and the overnaming (*Überbenennung*) of things by human tongues is the source of nature's mourning. Earthsea's mages are post-lapsarian Adamites who learn the Old Speech as a second language, and their power is the power of the name over the named. Genesis's Adam names the animals as an act of dominion (Gen. 2:19–20); Derrida's late lectures (2006) read that scene as the founding gesture of the human claim over the animal.

Le Guin's ethics of the name complicates the mastery. True names in Earthsea are given, never self-chosen: Ogion names the boy Duny "Ged" at the spring of the Ar (*WEa* ch. 1). They are kept secret and disclosed only to the trusted, and disclosure is reciprocal: Vetch entrusts Ged with his true name, Estarriol, and receives Ged's in return. The exchange is gift and counter-gift in Mauss's sense, and the name it circulates is not property but a pledge held by another. The self's deepest identity is something one has received and may entrust; it is never owned. Locke's self-proprietor is refuted in a gesture of Hardic etiquette.

4.2 The Shadow: Projection and Its Withdrawal

The first book's plot is a parable of the projectile. Provoked by Jasper's contempt, the young Ged performs a forbidden summoning of a dead spirit to display his power; the spell tears the world and looses a shadow that scars his face and then hunts him across the archipelago (*WEa* ch. 4). The act is *pro-icere* in every register: a throwing-forth of power at a rival, a summons across the boundary of death, a projection. Ogion counsels reversal: turn, and hunt the hunter. Ged pursues the shadow to the edge of the world, and when they meet he names it with his own name, and the two become one (*WEa* ch. 10).

Le Guin's essay "The Child and the Shadow" (1975) reads Andersen's "The Shadow" (1847), in which a man's detached shadow supplants and destroys him, through Jung's concept of the shadow: the unacknowledged part of the self that, unintegrated, is projected onto others. Jung's therapeutic vocabulary is exact. Individuation requires the withdrawal of projections, their taking back. The cure for projection is reception, and Ged's integration of the shadow is a *re-cipere*: the taking back of what he threw out. The Introduction's etymological dyad thus operates at the level of the psyche, and a children's book of 1968 is already a recipient text. The contrast with Stevenson's *Jekyll and Hyde* (1886) is instructive: there the shadow is expelled and destroys; here it is received and completes.

The dragon episode at Pendor confirms the pattern. Yevaud offers to tell Ged the shadow's name in exchange for his own freedom to range the islands; Ged refuses the bargain and binds the dragon by its name instead (*WEa* ch. 5). The shadow's name is not to be acquired as a commodity, and when it is found it proves to be his own. Earthsea's colors complete the dispossession of genre convention: Ged and most Archipelagans are brown- or red-brown-skinned and the Kargs white, and Le Guin's essay "A Whitewashed Earthsea" (2004) protested a television adaptation that recast her hero as white.

4.3 The Hoard and the Labyrinth

The Tombs of Atuan (1971) is a study of the corrupted container. Tenar, taken from her parents as a child and reborn as Arha, "the eaten one," serves the Nameless Ones at the Tombs; her domain is the Undertomb and the Labyrinth beneath it, where a Great Treasure lies that no one uses and no one may see (*TA*). The Labyrinth is the container as cage, holding its priestess as surely as its gold. Ged enters as a thief, seeking the lost half of the Ring of Erreth-Akbe; trapped in the dark, he is kept alive by Arha, who comes to recognize in him a person rather than a trespasser.

The ring is the book's emblem: a broken circle whose halves were held apart by two strangers, made whole only when both hold it. Tenar's liberation is a departure from the hoard, and the Tombs collapse behind her. The dragon of the inherited myth is a hoarder, from Fáfnir to Smaug, and Le Guin's first Earthsea story, "The Rule of Names" (1964), still turns on a dragon disguised as a village wizard and a stranger come to reclaim stolen treasure. The later books dismantle the topos. Le Guin's dragons become creatures of the wind, figures of freedom rather than possession (*OW*).

4.4 Cob's Hole: Immortality as the Last Possession

The Farthest Shore (1972) diagnoses a world losing its meaning. Wizards forget their spells, the silk-dyers of Lorbanery forget their craft, singers forget their songs. The cause is Cob, a sorcerer who, refusing death, has opened a breach between the living world and the dry land of the dead, through which meaning drains away (FS). The image is exact: the breach is a broken vessel. Cob's desire is the projectile's limit-case, the self that will not be released, immortality as the ultimate property.

Ged, with the young prince Arren (Lebannen), follows Cob into the dry land and closes the breach at the cost of all his power. His reproach to Cob is that he has traded the living world for a self that is nothing. The archmage returns powerless, carried home by the dragon Kalessin, and the Master Doorkeeper of Roke remarks that he has done with doing and gone home (FS). *Wuwei* becomes biography: the cycle's hero ends the first trilogy dispossessed of his mastery.

4.5 Re-Vision: *Tehanu*

Eighteen years later Le Guin published *Tehanu* (1990), subtitled *The Last Book of Earthsea*, a subtitle the later books revoked. In the lecture *Earthsea Revisioned* (1993), she describes the first trilogy as written within a heroic tradition whose masculine norms she had absorbed, and *Tehanu* as the book she could write only after the women's movement taught her to write as a woman. The title echoes Adrienne Rich's "When We Dead Awaken: Writing as Re-Vision" (1972), which defined re-vision as the act of looking back and entering an old text from a new critical direction.

Tehanu is that act. Tenar, a widowed farmer on Gont, takes in a child who has been raped and beaten by the adults of the vagrant band she lived with, a man called Handy among them, and then pushed into their fire and left for dead; the child, Therru, survives with half her face burned, one eye blinded, and one hand burned into a claw. Ged returns without power, and Le Guin makes the former archmage a man who must live without mastery: he herds goats, keeps house, and suffers the contempt power reserves for the powerless (*Teh*). The proverb of the first book, that women's magic is weak and wicked (*WEa* ch. 1), is examined from below. Aunt Moss, the village witch, describes a women's power rooted deeper than men's art and unaccountable to it. The wizard Aspen, servant of a lord who seeks to prolong his life, embodies institutional misogyny; with Handy, one of the men who raped the child, now at his side, he binds Tenar and Ged by spell and drives them toward a cliff edge to die; Therru calls Kalessin, who burns Aspen and those with him, names the burned child Tehanu, and calls her daughter (*Teh*).

Critics objected that *Tehanu* abandons magic for domestic realism (White 1999 surveys the reception). This dissertation reads it otherwise. The climax puts one of the men who raped the child and the wizard who despises women on the same side, and that alliance is the novel's argument: the violence of the household and the misogyny of the school are one power. The domestic is not the absence of magic but the site of the other magic, the magic of holding. *Tehanu* is also an answer to a question Le Guin had posed seventeen years earlier in "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas," an argument Chapter 7 develops.

4.6 The Hand: "The Finder" and the Suppressed Origin

Tales from Earthsea (2001) rewrites the archipelago's history. "The Finder" recounts the founding of the school on Roke in an age of warlords by a man called Otter, or Medra, and a secret league of women and men called the Hand, who preserved knowledge against the tyrants. Women taught at the founding; the school's later exclusion of women is revealed as a forgetting (*TE*). The founding league is named for the recipient's organ, and its erasure from Roke's memory is the archive's own act of possession. In "Dragonfly," a woman, Irian, comes to Roke's gate; refused, she walks into the Immanent Grove and is revealed as a dragon.

4.7 Breaking the Wall: *The Other Wind*

The Other Wind (2001) completes the argument. Alder, a village sorcerer, dreams each night of his dead wife, Lily, reaching for him across a low wall of stones in the dry land; the dead press against it, and the wall is failing (*OW*). A council of humans and dragons, Hardic and Kargish, king and witch, uncovers the history. In the primordial division called the Vedurnan, the ancestors of humans and dragons parted, humans choosing the yoke of making and owning, dragons choosing the wind. Long afterward, Hardic mages, wishing to possess even death, took part of the dragons' realm in the west and walled it off, so that human souls might keep their names forever. They made the dry land, a shadow-country where the dead endure without light or love. The afterlife was a collection.

The resolution is the breaking of the wall. The stones are pulled down; the dead pass through and are released into the other wind, into the world's own cycle, as Zhuangzi's wife returned to the changes of *qi* (Chapter 1). The Kargish belief in rebirth, long scorned by the Hardic peoples, is tacitly vindicated. Tehanu, the burned child, becomes a dragon and flies west with Irian (*OW*).

The Other Wind was published in 2001, a year after the repatriation and reburial of Ishi's brain (Chapter 3). The dissertation claims no biographical causation; it claims a structural homology. In both, an institution of keeping—the walled afterlife of the mages, the specimen collection of the museum—held the dead as possessions, cut off from return. In both, the ethical act is release. The corpus's last major novel performs in myth the act of repatriation that the history of its author's inheritance required.

4.8 "She Unnames Them"

The shortest text in the argument runs to a page. In "She Unnames Them" (1985), Eve undoes the names Adam gave the animals; the animals accept the release with something like relief, and the distance that names imposed between them and her falls away. Then Eve gives her own name back to Adam and leaves. The story reverses Genesis 2 and anticipates Derrida. Beside Earthsea it states the limit-case of Le Guin's ethics of the name: when names have become instruments of dominion, give them back.

Read together, the Earthsea books enact the three negative moments of recipient humanism. Dispossession of things: the hoard of the Tombs abandoned. Unnaming: the name as gift, and Eve's return of names. De-heroization extended to its last object: the self kept forever, released through the broken wall.

5

CHAPTER FIVE

Kemmer and the Carrier Bag: Gender, the Receptacle, and Feminist Poetics

> *Le Guin's feminism performs a transvaluation of the receptacle. The figure that Western metaphysics feminized and degraded into passive matter becomes in her hands an active technology, a mode of sexual being received in relation, and a narrative form, without being re-essentialized as the property of women.*

5.1 The Receptacle in Western Metaphysics

The container has a long misogynist history. Aeschylus's Apollo, defending Orestes, argues that the mother is not the parent of her child but only the nurse of the seed sown in her (*Eumenides* 658–61). Plato's *Timaeus* names the receptacle (*hypodochē*, 49a) and *chōra* (52a–b) as a third kind beside the forms and their copies: a nurse of becoming, itself formless, receiving every shape and possessing none. Aristotle's *Generation of Animals* assigns form and soul to the male and matter to the female. The receptive is feminized and devalued in one gesture: woman as vessel, matter, place.

Twentieth-century feminist philosophy answered in several registers. Simone de Beauvoir refused anatomy as destiny: one is not born but becomes a woman (*The Second Sex*, 1949). Luce Irigaray, reading *Physics* IV, showed that woman has served as place, envelope, and container for man without a place of her own (*An Ethics of Sexual Difference*, 1984). Julia Kristeva rehabilitated *chōra* as the pre-symbolic matrix of rhythm and drive (*Revolution in Poetic Language*, 1974), while Derrida's "Khōra" (1993) stressed its resistance to every determination, the feminine included. Difference feminism (Cixous 1975; Daly 1978) revalued the feminine as such; constructionism refused the question.

Le Guin's move is neither revaluation nor refusal. She does not praise the container as feminine; she reclassifies it as technology. The carrier bag is made by hands, not grown in a body; it is the first cultural device, not the first organ. Once the vessel is technique rather than anatomy, it belongs to anyone who carries.

5.2 Gethen: Sex as Received

The Left Hand of Darkness is a thought experiment, as the 1976 introduction insists, in the physicist's sense: not a prediction but a description of the present by means of a controlled alteration. Gethenians are ambisexual. For most of a monthly cycle (somer) they are sexually latent; in kemmer, a few days each month, an individual becomes male or female, and which one depends on the partner. Hormonal interaction determines that one will become male and the other female, and neither knows in advance or chooses (*LHD* ch. 7, the field notes of the Investigator Ong Tot Oppong). Anyone can bear a child and anyone can sire one.

The Investigator draws the consequences: no division of humanity into strong and weak halves, no sexual division of labor, burden and privilege evenly shared, each person judged as a human being rather than as a man or a woman. Gethenians regard a permanently sexed being as a pervert, and so they regard Genly Ai. The novel's most quoted sentence announces, deadpan, that the king was pregnant.

The reading proposed here is that Gethenian sex is *received*. It is neither an essence one has, as in biological essentialism, nor a performance one authors, as in the constructionist and later performative model of Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990). In kemmer, sex is given by the encounter: it arrives from the other, through the relation, for a time, and is then released. Sex becomes an event rather than a property, a season rather than an identity, fittingly on a planet called Winter, where kemmer is a weather of the body.

This is a genuine third position. It concedes biology to the essentialist, since kemmer is hormonal and unchosen, and contingency to the constructionist, since no Gethenian has a sex outside a relation. It refuses the possessive premise both share: that sex is something one owns, whether as nature or as authorship.

Genly's arc is the education of a projectile perceiver into a recipient one. He begins by sorting every Gethenian into man or woman and reading Estraven's femininity as duplicity. On the Gobrin Ice he finally sees Estraven as both, and accepts what he had been afraid to see. When Estraven enters kemmer on the Ice, the two choose not to become lovers; their love is held rather than taken. Estraven dies skiing into the guns of a border patrol, and Genly's report becomes the vessel that carries him home, to his father and his child at Estre.

5.3 The Pronoun and the Redux: Self-Revision as Method

Feminist readers objected that the Gethenians read as men: the generic "he," Estraven's political and physical roles, the absence of scenes of Gethenian parenting, the default heterosexuality of kemmer pairs (LeFanu 1988; White 1999 surveys the debate). The 1976 essay "Is Gender Necessary?" defended the novel. Its 1987 republication as "Is Gender Necessary? Redux" (*DEW*) printed bracketed annotations that withdraw the defense point by point: the generic pronoun was a mistake; Estraven should have been shown with children; Gethenians had been locked into heterosexuality without need. Le Guin had already revised "Winter's King" (1969) for its 1975 collection so that every Gethenian is "she" while keeping masculine titles such as king and lord. "Coming of Age in Karhide" (1995) narrates first kemmer from inside a kemmerhouse, frankly and without the Terran observer's discomfort.

The method matters more than the corrections. Le Guin revises in public and lets the earlier text stand: the 1976 essay is not deleted but annotated. Revision of this kind is itself

recipient, holding the earlier self without disowning it, taking back the projection without erasing the throw. Rich's re-vision (Chapter 4) becomes a practice of the archive. "Introducing Myself" (1992), in which Le Guin deadpans that she is a man, since the generic man includes her, dramatizes the absurdity of the pronoun she once used.

5.4 Comparative Utopias of Sex

Gethen sits among the century's feminist experiments with sex, and comparison clarifies its specificity. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) imagines a parthenogenetic society of women organized around collective motherhood, a maternal state whose eugenic and racial premises have rightly troubled later readers. Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain's "Sultana's Dream" (1905) inverts purdah: in Ladyland, men are secluded while women govern by science. Le Guin's "The Matter of Seggri" (1994) rewrites that inversion with satirical exactness, on a world where scarce men are kept in castles for sport and breeding while women hold every other power, and the arrangement is a tragedy for both sexes.

Joanna Russ's "When It Changed" (1972) and *The Female Man* (1975) imagine Whileaway, a world without men, to which the return of men is an invasion. Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976) realizes Shulamith Firestone's program in *The Dialectic of Sex* (1970), the liberation of women through the technological abolition of biological reproduction: in Mattapoisett children are gestated in brooders, have three co-mothers of either sex, men nurse, and the pronoun is "per." Octavia E. Butler's Xenogenesis trilogy (1987–89) adds a third sex, the ooloi, who take up, hold, and recombine the genetic material of others: recipients in the literal sense, whose holding is also coercive. Ann Leckie's *Ancillary Justice* (2013) adopts a universal "she" in the language of an empire that annexes worlds and turns captured bodies into extensions of its ships' minds.

Three contrasts follow. Against Firestone and Piercy, Le Guin does not free persons from the body by technology; she redistributes the body's capacities across all persons. Against the separatist utopias of Gilman and Russ, she abolishes neither sex; she temporalizes both. Against Leckie, whose ungendered language coexists with absolute imperial possession, she shows that a reform of pronouns without a reform of property changes little, which is why her sexual, economic, and political thought must be read as one structure. Butler's ooloi mark the danger internal to recipience itself: holding that does not ask is possession.

5.5 Woman the Gatherer: The Taphonomy of the Hero

"The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986; *DEW*) begins in paleoanthropology. Following Elizabeth Fisher's *Woman's Creation* (1979), Le Guin observes that most of the food of early humans was gathered rather than hunted, and that the first cultural device was probably a container—a recipient, in the essay's own word—to hold gathered things and carry infants. The hunter's story is short, violent, and exciting. It is the killer story, the story of the Hero, and it has crowded out every other. Fisher's argument descends from Sally Slocum's critique of the Man the Hunter paradigm (1975), and it was reinforced by Nancy Tanner and Adrienne Zihlman's "Women in Evolution" (1976).

The essay omits an argument that strengthens it decisively: the bias is taphonomic. Stone points survive in the archaeological record; bags, nets, slings, and baskets of fiber and skin

rot. Elizabeth Wayland Barber's *Women's Work: The First 20,000 Years* (1994) reconstructed a "String Revolution" from rare traces of cordage, and J. M. Adovasio, Olga Soffer, and Jake Page's *The Invisible Sex* (2007) argued that perishable technologies, much of them women's work, have been systematically invisible to a discipline that digs for durable things. The hero narrative is in part a preservation artifact: we tell the story of the spear because only the spear survived. Recipient anthropology is an anthropology of the perishable, and recovering it requires what Le Guin practices: imagination disciplined by evidence about what does not last.

The argument turns against Arendt (Chapter 2). *The Human Condition* ranks the durable world of *homo faber* above the perishable round of the *animal laborans*, whose sphere is the household, and reserves the immortality conferred by story for action in public. The carrier bag reverses the derivation. The perishable, cyclical labor of gathering produced the first container, and the container is the first form of story. Arendt's hierarchy is itself a taphonomic artifact.

5.6 The Carrier Bag as Poetics

The essay's claim about narrative is formal: a novel is a medicine bundle, a bag holding things in particular relations to one another and to us, rather than an arrow aimed at a climax. Le Guin's novels are built this way. *The Left Hand of Darkness* is a dossier: Genly's report, Estraven's journal, Gethenian legends, an earlier Investigator's field notes, an Orgota creation myth, gathered rather than plotted. *The Dispossessed* is a two-chambered vessel whose alternating compartments are filled toward a meeting. *Always Coming Home* is a basket of genres. Earthsea, with *Tales from Earthsea*, becomes a carrier bag correcting the hero's quest it began as.

Mikhail Bakhtin's account of the polyphonic novel (*Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, 1929; rev. 1963), a novel whose voices are not subordinated to a single authorial consciousness, names the formal property. Fittingly, Bakhtin found it in Dostoevsky, whom Le Guin loved and inverted (Chapter 2). The carrier-bag novel is polyphony understood not as a contest of ideas but as a practice of holding many voices without owning them.

Lavinia (2008) is the corpus's most explicit experiment with the woman as vessel. In the *Aeneid*, Lavinia is the bride over whom the second half's war is fought, the vessel of the Roman line, who scarcely speaks. Le Guin gives her the narration: she knows she exists because a poet gave her a few lines, and she meets the poet's dying spirit. The dynastic vessel of Aeschylus's Apollo becomes the narrating holder of her own story. Christa Wolf's *Cassandra* (1983), Margaret Atwood's *The Penelopiad* (2005), and Madeline Miller's *Circe* (2018) likewise recover voiceless women of epic, but only Le Guin makes reception her heroine's mode of being: Lavinia receives her life from Virgil and gives it back as story.

5.7 Mother Tongue, Father Tongue, Native Tongue

The Bryn Mawr Commencement Address (1986; *DEW*) distinguishes three languages. The father tongue is the language of power and distance, the lecture and the report, spoken from above and expecting no answer. The mother tongue is the language of relation, conversation and story, spoken to someone and awaiting reply. The writer's native tongue is the dialectic of the two. Le Guin closes by asking women to offer their experience as human truth, at which point, she says, the maps change and there are new mountains.

The triad has a humanist pedigree Le Guin knew professionally. Dante opposes the vernacular, received from the nurse without rules, to *grammatica*, the secondary, learned, and regulated language, and judges the vernacular the nobler (*De vulgari eloquentia* I.i.2–4): mother tongue against father tongue, six centuries early. Du Bellay's *Deffence* and Lemaire's *Concorde des deux langages* belong to the same debate. Le Guin's mother tongue is therefore not an *écriture féminine* in Cixous's sense, a writing of the female body. It is the received tongue of the vernacular tradition, which belongs to anyone who was spoken to as a child. The linguistic form of recipient humanism is a received language: conversational, answerable, given.

5.8 The Fisherwoman's Daughter and the Space Crone

Two essays relocate feminist poetics in time. "The Fisherwoman's Daughter" (1988; *DEW*) takes its title from Virginia Woolf's figure, in "Professions for Women" (1931), of the woman writer as a fisherwoman whose imagination, let down into the depths, strikes against something about the body that convention forbids her to say. Informed by Tillie Olsen's *Silences* (1978), the essay contests the doctrine that a woman writer must choose between books and children; Le Guin wrote while raising three, and she makes the household not the enemy of writing but one of its sources. "Science Fiction and Mrs. Brown" (1976) had already answered Woolf's "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown" (1924) by asking whether science fiction could hold an ordinary person.

"The Space Crone" (1976; *DEW*) proposes that if humanity had to send one representative to another species, it should send an old woman past menopause, someone who has passed through the change of life, borne its losses, and knows the full length of human experience. The crone, invisible to a culture of youth, is the most complete human. The essay prefigures Tenar and Aunt Moss (Chapter 4) and the late essays on age (*No Time to Spare*, 2017). It also completes the transvaluation of the receptacle: the woman who has ceased to be a vessel of reproduction becomes the vessel of a life's experience, and the species' representative.

6

CHAPTER SIX

Cold Utopia: Time, Ecology, and the Politics of Not-Doing

> *Le Guin's ecological and temporal thought extends the recipient figure to history. Against the hot utopia of the blueprint and the arrow of progress, she imagines a cold utopia that holds time rather than spending it, and she finds in vegetal, animal, and even mineral lives other holders whose existence decenters the human without abolishing its vocation.*

6.1 Yin Utopia and the Cold Society

The 1982 lecture "A Non-Euclidean View of California as a Cold Place to Be" (*DEW*) is Le Guin's theory of utopia. The tradition that runs from Plato's *Republic* through More's *Utopia* (1516), Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627), Bellamy's *Looking Backward* (1888), and Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948) is, she argues, Euclidean: rational, centralized, progressive, and planned in advance. It is a yang utopia, bright, hot, dry, and hard, and its straight lines run forward. Le Guin asks instead for a yin utopia: dark, wet, cold, receptive, cyclical, decentralized, and slow, a utopia whose lines curve back on themselves, as lines do in non-Euclidean space and in Shevek's physics.

The thermal vocabulary comes from Lévi-Strauss, who distinguished "hot" societies, which internalize their own history and make it the engine of their development, from "cold" societies, which use their institutions to annul history's effects on their structure and persist in equilibrium (Charbonnier 1961; Lévi-Strauss 1962). Le Guin's proposal is that a utopia worth wanting might be a cold society by choice: a people who step off the train of progress not from ignorance of its destination but from knowledge of it. Clastres's societies against the state (1974) supply its political form, and the Kesh are its fiction (Chapter 3). Le Guin returned to the distinction three decades later in "Utopiyin, Utopiyang" (2016), observing that every yang utopia conceals a dystopia for someone.

The cold utopia also revises Ernst Bloch. *The Principle of Hope* is a philosophy of the Not-Yet, of anticipation leaning forward; its hope is hot. Le Guin's is a cold hope, a hope of return, in which the Not-Yet is approached as a homecoming rather than an arrival; Bloch's own last word, *Heimat*, already pointed that way (Chapter 1). The utopian debate of the 1970s bears the mark of the difference. Samuel R. Delany answered *The Dispossessed* with *Triton:*

An Ambiguous Heterotopia (1976), a plural, sexually fluid, technologically saturated society, and with an essay, "To Read *The Dispossessed*" (1977), that faulted the novel's marginal treatment of homosexuality, carried by its gay character Bedap, and its rhetorical stacking of the deck. Delany's heterotopia is hot, endlessly various and endlessly productive. Le Guin's utopia is cold: few things, held well.

6.2 World-Reduction and the Daily Decrease

Jameson's 1975 essay identified the method by which Le Guin builds such worlds. "World-reduction" is a deliberate thinning of empirical reality—the subtraction of gender difference, war, and seasonal variety on Gethen; the material poverty of Anarres—by which the utopian imagination isolates what it means to examine. Jameson read the method as symptomatic of an age unable to imagine fullness otherwise than by excision.

The Daoist tradition reads the same method as a positive discipline. In pursuit of learning, something is added every day; in pursuit of the Way, something is dropped every day, and dropped again, until one arrives at not-doing (*DDJ* 48). Le Guin's utopian method is subtraction because her ontology locates use in emptiness (Chapter 1): one empties the vessel to make room. Her utopias are poor—Anarres dry, Gethen cold, the Kesh technologically modest—not because poverty is good but because subtraction reveals what holds. Jameson's diagnosis and Laozi's practice describe one technique from two sides. What the Marxist critic saw as a symptom, the Daoist reader sees as a cure.

6.3 The Semley Principle: Relativistic Time and the Price of Possession

Le Guin's first Hainish story, "Semley's Necklace" (1964; the prologue to *Rocannon's World*, 1966), is a parable of possession and time. Semley, a noblewoman of a declining house on a distant world, travels to the stars to recover a lost heirloom, a jeweled necklace that would restore her family's standing. She finds it held in a museum of the League of All Worlds, whose curators give it to her. Because the journey is made at nearly the speed of light, a few nights for her are many years at home. She returns with the treasure to find her husband dead and the infant daughter she left a grown woman, and she flees, broken, into the wild (WTQ).

I call this the Semley principle: every possessive quest across relativistic distance is paid for in the possessor's own lifetime. The museum episode is remarkable in light of Chapter 3. The Hainish cycle opens, in 1964, with a repatriation from a collection, and the corpus's last major novel closes, in 2001, with another release from a walled keeping. The first is paid for in grief because its motive is possession; the second redeems because its motive is release.

The Ekumen's technology answers the principle. Shevek's theory makes the ansible possible (Chapter 2): communication without travel, news without fetching, contact without the Semley price. The ansible is the temporal form of the gift. It lets worlds receive one another without consuming one another's time.

6.4 Vegetal Mind

"Vaster than Empires and More Slow" (1971) takes its title from Marvell's "To His Coy Mistress" (1681), whose speaker imagines a "vegetable love" growing "vaster than empires, and more slow." A survey team lands on a world without animals, covered by forest and grassland whose plants are linked, root to root, into a single slow sentience. The crew's mounting terror proves to be the forest's own: a mind that has never known another experiences the intruders as fear, and returns it. The resolution belongs to Osden, a man of rare empathic capacity who receives, unfiltered, the emotions of everyone near him and is hated by his crewmates for what he receives. Osden walks into the forest, accepts its fear, and stays, and the terror ends (WTQ).

Osden is the recipient at its extreme: a man who cannot help receiving, who finally chooses what he receives and holds it. The story imagines a planetary root-network intelligence a quarter-century before mycorrhizal research made the "wood-wide web" a popular image (Simard et al. 1997), and four decades before Michael Marder's *Plant-Thinking* (2013) and Eduardo Kohn's *How Forests Think* (2013) gave vegetal cognition a philosophy. "Direction of the Road" (1973), narrated by an oak that must, out of courtesy, appear to approach and recede from the travelers who pass it, supplies the comic counterpart: a tree's dignity offended by a human who drives into it.

6.5 Therolinguistics

"The Author of the Acacia Seeds and Other Extracts from the *Journal of the Association of Therolinguistics*" (1974) is a set of mock-scholarly reports: the decipherment of a text left by an ant in touch-gland secretions on acacia seeds; the kinetic sea-poetry of penguins; and an editorial that anticipates a phytolinguistics able to read the poetry of plants and, beyond it, a geolinguistics of the slow lyric of stone. The story formalizes the dispute between Zhuangzi and Huizi on the bridge over the Hao. How can you know the fish are happy, asks Huizi; how can you know that I do not know, answers Zhuangzi (ZZ 17).

Therolinguistics fixes the human vocation in a decentered world. Humans are not the only holders or the only authors: ants write, penguins compose, plants and stones may have literatures. But reading them is a human task, and specifically the philologist's. The humanism Le Guin learned as a student of sixteenth-century poetry survives here, extended from texts in dead languages to texts in nonhuman ones, and Edward Said's late defense of a philological humanism (2004) finds an unexpected ally in an ant. The story parodies the father tongue of academic reporting while performing the mother-tongue act of listening.

6.6 *Paradises Lost* and the Refusal of Transcendence

"Paradises Lost" (2002) follows the fifth generation of a ship two centuries into its voyage toward a habitable planet. A religious movement, Bliss, teaches that the ship is already heaven and that landing would be a fall; when the ship arrives, the faithful vote to continue the voyage forever. The protagonists, Hsing and Luis, choose to land, and accept weather, mud, insects, illness, and death on a living world. The ship departs with the believers.

The ship of Bliss and the dry land of Earthsea are one image: a sealed container that keeps its selves forever and refuses the perishable world. It is the vessel corrupted into a cage of

transcendence. Contemporary techno-immortalism, from the uploaded mind of Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Near* (2005) to Yuval Noah Harari's *Homo Deus* (2016), is its secular form. Le Guin's judgment is consistent from Cob (1972) to Bliss (2002): the self kept forever is the last possession, and the last possession is the worst. The recipient chooses the planet.

6.7 Realists of a Larger Reality

Accepting the National Book Foundation's Medal for Distinguished Contribution to American Letters in November 2014, Le Guin foresaw hard times in which writers would be needed who could imagine alternatives to how we live now, "realists of a larger reality." She reminded her audience that capitalism's power seems inescapable, as the divine right of kings once did, and that any human power can be resisted and changed by human beings. Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) argued two years later that serious fiction had failed to imagine climate change because the modern realist novel had banished the improbable into genre. Le Guin had made the same argument from inside the banished genre for four decades.

Her late talk "Deep in Admiration" (2017), given to a gathering on the Anthropocene, states the last term of the arc. Science, she proposed, describes accurately from outside and poetry accurately from inside, and both honor what they describe; what the moment requires is a turn from mastery of the world to kinship with it. Bruno Latour's call to become "terrestrial" (2017) and Haraway's injunction to make kin in the Chthulucene (2016) belong to the same moment.

Heidegger had named the alternative Le Guin refuses. Modern technology, he argued, enframes the earth as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), stock on call to be ordered ("The Question Concerning Technology," 1954). Haber's lathe, the sawmills of Athshe, and the Corporation of Aka treat the world as *Bestand*; the *Daodejing*'s world is a numinous vessel that cannot be worked upon (*DDJ* 29). Between stock and vessel lies the whole of Le Guin's ecology, and Heidegger's own lecture on the jug (Introduction) shows that the alternative was available within the tradition that produced the enframing.

PART THREE

Limits and Synthesis



CHAPTER 7

From Exit to Carrying

Omelas, Yeowe, and the Ethics of the Burden

CHAPTER 8

Homo Recipiens

Principles of a Recipient Humanism

7

CHAPTER SEVEN

From Exit to Carrying: Omelas, Yeowe, and the Ethics of the Burden

The strongest objection to recipient humanism is that it counsels withdrawal in the face of injustice, and Le Guin's most famous story seems to prove it. This chapter argues that the oeuvre registers the objection and answers it, moving from an ethics of exit in "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) to an ethics of carrying in Tehanu (1990), with "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) as the hinge.

7.1 The Scapegoat Economy

"The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973; Hugo Award, 1974) invites the reader to build a festival city of complete happiness and then discloses its condition. In a basement room a child of nearly ten, who looks six, is kept naked and alone, sitting in its own excrement and fed half a bowl of cornmeal and grease a day; the citizens who come to look at it sometimes kick it to make it stand. The story calls it "feeble-minded" and leaves open whether it was born so or made so by fear, hunger, and neglect. If it were brought into the light, cleaned, fed, comforted, even spoken to kindly, the city's happiness would end. Every citizen knows. Most, after a time, accept the terms, telling themselves that the child is by now too degraded to profit from freedom: the condition the city inflicted becomes its reason for continuing to inflict it. A few leave, singly, walking out of the city into the dark, and do not come back (WTQ).

The subtitle, "Variations on a Theme by William James," names the source. James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891) imagines millions kept permanently happy on the single condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture, and holds that our moral sense would refuse the bargain. Le Guin's headnote acknowledges that the same scapegoat appears in *The Brothers Karamazov*, in Ivan's rebellion against a harmony bought with a child's tears, and admits she had forgotten it, not having reread Dostoevsky since her youth. The figure is older still: the goat sent into the wilderness bearing the community's sins (Lev. 16). René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred*

(1972), published the year before "Omelas," made the scapegoat the founding mechanism of social order, in which communities cohere by uniting against a victim. Omelas is Girard's community with a single alteration: its victim is not killed but kept.

7.2 Rawls, Williams, Agamben

The philosophical context is exact. Rawls's *A Theory of Justice* (1971) had just refuted utilitarian aggregation in the abstract: the difference principle forbids buying the welfare of the many with the misery of the worst-off. Omelas is the utilitarian calculus dramatized as a reductio. Bernard Williams's critique of utilitarianism (Smart and Williams 1973), with its defense of the agent's integrity against the demands of aggregate welfare, describes the walkers precisely: they do not compute; they cannot stay.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) supplies a later and darker frame. Sovereign order, Agamben argues, rests on bare life included through its exclusion, the life that may be killed but not sacrificed, and the camp is the hidden paradigm of the modern polity. The child in the basement is *homo sacer*: excluded from the city's life and the condition of it, held in a camp of one, under a permanent state of exception that every citizen ratifies by knowing.

7.3 Exit and Voice

Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) distinguishes the two responses open to members of a failing institution: to leave it, or to protest within it. The walkers choose exit. N. K. Jemisin's "The Ones Who Stay and Fight" (2018) answers Le Guin directly: in the city of Um-Helat, happiness is sustained by an active and sometimes violent vigilance against the hatred that would produce an Omelas. Jemisin chooses voice, and her title carries the charge: those who walk away leave the child where it is.

Exit is not nothing. David Graeber and David Wengrow (2021) count the freedom to move away among the three primordial social freedoms, with the freedoms to disobey and to reorganize social relations. Scott's Zomia (2009) is a history of exit from the state, and Le Guin's anarchism is structurally an anarchism of exodus: the Odonians leave Urras, the Shantih of *The Eye of the Heron* leave the City, the Kesh descend from those who left the industrial world. The walkers belong to a respectable political lineage.

7.4 The Missing Gesture

The story's own terms nonetheless expose the limit of exit. The condition of Omelas forbids not only liberating the child but even a kind word to it, and the walkers obey these terms even in leaving. They go alone. No one speaks to the child; no one takes it with them. Their exit leaves the structure intact and the child in place. Their refusal is a refusal to possess a happiness bought with the child, which is a dispossession, but it is not a holding. In the vocabulary of Chapter 8, it is release corrupted into abandonment: they let go of Omelas and of the child in a single motion.

The missing gesture is carrying. No one in Omelas picks the child up. The recipient act would be to carry the child out of the basement, accepting that the city's happiness would end. It is neither exit nor voice but a third term absent from Hirschman's schema: carrying, which breaks the terms by touching what the terms forbid one to touch. The only words the

story gives the child are a plea to be let out and a promise to be good. The city's answer to that promise is the whole architecture of its happiness.

7.5 *Tehanu* as the Answer to Omelas

Seventeen years after "Omelas," and four after the carrier bag essay, Le Guin wrote the missing gesture. Therru is the Omelas child given a name: a girl raped, beaten, pushed into a fire, and left for dead by the adults she lived with, marked by what they did to her, whose suffering the surrounding world prefers not to see. Tenar picks her up. She carries her, literally and through the long labor of raising her, and pays for it: the revulsion of neighbors, the return of Handy, one of the men who raped the child, the curse of a wizard who despises women (*Teh*). Carrying costs exactly what the walkers declined to pay, the end of a certain comfort.

Tehanu also completes the four movements. Tenar receives Therru; holds her, raising without ruling, in the formula of *xuande*; carries her through danger; and in *The Other Wind* releases her to the dragons, with whom she flies west. In Le Guin's revision, the excluded child is not merely rescued. She becomes the one who flies: the life once kept below the house becomes the freest life in the cycle.

The chapter's claim is that Le Guin's oeuvre answered its own most famous story, and answered Jemisin's critique in advance, though differently: not by fighting the hatred but by carrying the hurt. The answer has a limit. Carrying is not a program for a city, and *Tehanu* stays on a farm. But the farm is where the Omelas child lives, in the basement of the house. The feminist principle that the personal is political (Hanisch 1970) becomes here an ethical claim about where injustice is kept: in the domestic underfloor of public happiness, where only someone willing to carry can reach it.

7.6 Liberation and Its Remainders

Four Ways to Forgiveness (1995) tests carrying at the scale of peoples. Werel is a world of owners and "assets," or slaves, in which caste is coded by skin and darker skin marks the owners, an estranging inversion of the racial coding of Atlantic slavery. Yeowe is its colony, where the assets rose in a long war of liberation. In "A Woman's Liberation," Rakam, born an asset, narrates her life in the form of the slave narrative—rape from girlhood by the men who owned and oversaw her, flight, freedom—and then discovers on liberated Yeowe that men's liberation has meant the continuation of women's servitude, sexual servitude included, under the freed men who now hold power; she finds freedom only through learning (FWF). The form recalls Harriet Jacobs's *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl* (1861), in which Jacobs testified in her own person to years of sexual coercion by her enslaver, Dr. James Norcom of Edenton, North Carolina, whom she called Dr. Flint; she bore witness as Frederick Douglass's *Narrative* (1845) could not.

Audre Lorde warned that the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house (1984). Yeowe dramatizes the warning: the liberated took up the masters' tools and turned them on women. Liberation by repossession, taking back what was taken and becoming owners in turn, reproduces possession. Liberation by dispossession, abolishing the ownership of persons, the ownership of women included, is harder and slower. The

forgiveness of the title is Arendt's faculty (Chapter 2): a release from the past that neither erases nor forgets. In "Forgiveness Day," an Ekumenical envoy and a soldier of the owner caste, held captive together, move from contempt to respect; in "Betrayals," two old people on Yeowe, one a fallen leader of the liberation, forgive what cannot be undone. Le Guin's essay "A War Without End" (WM) draws the moral for the writer: imagination is dangerous to those who profit from the way things are, because it shows that the way things are is neither permanent nor necessary.

7.7 Violence as Contaminant

The Word for World Is Forest (Chapter 3) and *The Eye of the Heron* (1978) frame the problem of violence. On the colony world Victoria, the City, founded by deported criminals and ruled by Bosses, confronts the Shantih, the People of the Peace, descended from pacifists deported from Earth after a nonviolent Long March. Le Guin later recounted that she had meant the young Shantih rebel Lev to be the protagonist, but he died in the book's violent climax and the novel turned out to belong to Luz, the Boss's daughter who joins the Shantih. Nonviolence and the turn to a woman protagonist arrive together. The Shantih then leave to found a new settlement—exit again—but this exit is collective, and it carries someone with it.

Fanon (1961) held that the colonized's violence against the colonizer is cathartic and constitutive, a purgation through which the colonized become subjects. Gandhi's *Hind Swaraj* (1909) and Thoreau's "Resistance to Civil Government" (1849) stand on the other side. Le Guin's Selver contradicts the cathartic thesis without endorsing absolute pacifism. His revolt is not condemned, but violence, once learned, is not purged. It is carried, and it must be carried consciously by those who chose it, lest it pass unexamined to those who did not. This is the recipient's theory of violence: not a verdict on its justification but an account of its weight.

Recipient humanism is therefore not quietism. Its political form is carrying: the child out of the basement, the burden of the violence one has chosen, the forgiven past. Its characteristic failure, abandonment, is exactly what "Omelas" anatomizes, and the oeuvre's later books supply the gesture that story withheld.

8

CHAPTER EIGHT

Homo Recipiens: Principles of a Recipient Humanism

> *Recipient humanism can be stated as a theory: an anthropology of four movements and four corruptions, grounded in a void that enables rather than lacks, distinguishable from its nearest neighbors, and able to guide judgment in cases Le Guin did not write.*

8.1 Prometheus, Epimetheus, and Pandora's Jar

Hesiod tells the projectile's myth and buries the recipient's inside it (*Theogony* 507–616; *Works and Days* 42–105). Prometheus, "forethought," steals fire for humankind. Zeus answers with a gift: Pandora, fashioned by the gods, whom Epimetheus, "afterthought," receives despite his brother's warning. She opens her storage jar (*pithos*), the evils scatter over the earth, and only Hope remains inside, beneath the rim. Hesiod's misogyny is explicit: the first woman is a beautiful evil (*Theogony* 585), and her jar is the origin of human suffering.

Two humanist translations mark the vessel's fate. Erasmus, retelling the myth in his *Adagia* (1508), turned the *pithos*, the household jar for grain, oil, and wine, into a *pyxis*, a small box, and "Pandora's box" was born (Panofsky and Panofsky 1956). Nearly four centuries later, Legge turned Zhuangzi's potter's wheel into a lathe (Chapter 1). In both cases a vessel of household holding became something else, a casket of secrets or a machine for cutting, and in both the substitution expresses the projectile anthropology of the translator's culture.

Bernard Stiegler's *Technics and Time* (1994) reads another version of the myth, from Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322a), in which Epimetheus distributes qualities to the animals and forgets humankind, leaving it naked and unarmed until Prometheus steals fire and the arts. For Stiegler the human is constituted by this "default of origin," a lack supplemented by technics: the human is the prosthetic being. Read through *DDJ* 11, the fault of Epimetheus is not a defect but a void, the emptiness in which use lies. Stiegler's default becomes Laozi's *wu*, and the first prosthesis, as Fisher and Le Guin argue, was not Promethean fire but a pouch.

Le Guin's choice of name for the doubting author-figure of *Always Coming Home* completes the reversal (Chapter 3). Pandora, the woman with the jar, carries a whole future culture, and what she unpacks from it is Hope. Even Prometheus can be converted. Shelley's

Titan (1820) is freed not by defiance but by revoking his curse: at the climax of the Romantic century's greatest anarchist poem, the projectile opens its hand.

8.2 Four Movements and Their Corruptions

The recipient's practice unfolds in four movements, each with a characteristic corruption. Table 2 states them with their paradigm cases in the corpus.

TABLE 2 · THE FOUR MOVEMENTS AND THEIR CORRUPTIONS

Movement	Definition	Paradigm in Le Guin	Corruption	Paradigm of corruption
Receiving	Taking in what is offered, on the giver's terms	The Ekumen's envoy; kemmer; Lyubov	Appropriation (the collection)	Ishi's brain; the Athshe colony; Haber
Holding	Keeping in trust, for later and for others	Shevek and Takver's promise; the entrusted name; the Telling's library	Hoarding (the hoard)	The treasure of the Tombs; Sabul; A-Io's bid for the theory
Carrying	Bearing across space and time for another's sake	The carrier bag; Tenar and Therru; Selver's burden; Genly's report	Confinement (the cage)	The Omelas basement; Arha's Labyrinth; the ship of Bliss
Releasing	Letting go, giving away, forgiving, letting perish	Shevek's gift; Zhuangzi's drum; the broken wall; forgiveness on Werel	Abandonment (the walk-away)	The walkers of Omelas; Victor Frankenstein

Each corruption is a hardening. Appropriation hardens the openness of reception into a claim; hoarding hardens holding into accumulation; confinement hardens carrying into captivity; abandonment hardens release into the refusal of relation. The wall is their general form, the membrane that has ceased to breathe (Chapter 2).

The table is also a diagnostic instrument. Of any practice—an archive, a border, a marriage, a theory, a technology—one may ask which movement it performs and whether it has hardened. The four questions are simple; their application is the work of judgment that Le Guin's fictions model and do not replace.

8.3 The Biology and Psychology of Holding

Recipient humanism has a biological floor. Endosymbiosis (Chapter 2) places holding without consuming at the origin of complex life. Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela's theory of autopoiesis (1980) defines the living as a self-producing system bounded by a membrane of its own making, and Haraway's sympoiesis (2016) recasts life as making-with. The membrane is life's boundary; the wall is death's.

It has a psychological floor as well. D. W. Winnicott's "holding environment" (1960) names the condition in which an infant's true self can emerge: the reliable, attuned holding of a good-enough caregiver, whose aim is not possession but the child's eventual independence. Where holding fails, a false self forms around compliance. Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* (1989) describes the practices of preservative love, nurturance, and training as work anyone may do, whatever their sex. Ogion and Tenar are Winnicottian holders: they hold in order to let go. Selves, like cells, begin in being held.

8.4 Differentiations

Recipient humanism differs from its nearest neighbors in definable ways.

From Promethean and possessive humanism (Pico, Bacon, Locke, Sartre), it differs by refusing self-ownership and dominion. The self is received and entrusted, never owned (Chapters 2 and 4).

From care ethics (Gilligan 1982; Noddings 1984; Tronto 1993), it differs in scope rather than spirit. Tronto's four phases of care—caring about, taking care of, care-giving, and care-receiving—already end in reception. Recipient humanism shares care ethics' relational ontology but extends it from interpersonal morality to ontology (the useful void), economics (dispossession), epistemology (unnaming), temporality (return), mortality (release), and narrative form (the carrier bag). It also makes release, not only care, constitutive.

From Butler and Athanasiou's *Dispossession* (2013), it differs by adding a third term. They distinguish dispossession as violent privation of land, rights, and livelihood from dispossession as the constitutive relationality of a self that is beside itself, undone by others. Le Guin adds dispossession as chosen practice, the Odonian refusal of property, and joins it to holding, so that the dispossessed self is not only vulnerable but capable: empty hands can carry.

From Levinas and Derrida, it differs in its organ. Levinas founds ethics on the face that commands, and assigns the welcome of the dwelling to "the feminine" (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961), a passage both Irigaray and Derrida contested. Recipient humanism ungenders welcome and moves it from the face, which commands, to the hand, which holds.

From posthumanism (Haraway 1985; Hayles 1999; Wolfe 2010; Braidotti 2013), it differs by keeping the human. It decenters the human—ants write, forests feel, cells hold—but retains a specific human vocation: making vessels, promises, and stories, and listening to the other holders. It answers Sylvia Wynter's critique of "Man" (2003), the Western bourgeois self-description that overrepresents itself as the human, by being assembled from the figures "Man" excluded: the gatherer, the Californian, the slave of Werel, the child in the basement, the crone. Wynter's critique also binds it. To build a humanism from excluded figures risks a new appropriation (Chapter 3), so the theory must carry its own Pandora sections, its own doubt.

From the spiritualities of emptying—Simone Weil's *décréation* and her account of attention as the rarest and purest form of generosity, Iris Murdoch's "unselfing" (1970), Keats's negative capability (1817), the capacity to remain in uncertainty without irritable reaching after fact and reason—it takes the discipline of attention and refuses the ascetic end. The hand empties in order to hold the world, not to leave it.

8.5 The Hospitality of the Hand

The organ of recipient humanism is the hand. André Leroi-Gourhan (1964–65) made the hand freed by upright posture the axis of human evolution, with the tool as its partner. Heidegger's lecture course *What Is Called Thinking?* (1951–52) called thinking a handicraft and catalogued the hand's acts: reaching, receiving, welcoming, holding, carrying, signing. Derrida's "Geschlecht II" (1987) exposed the exclusion on which the catalogue rested, Heidegger's claim that apes have organs for grasping but no hands. Recipient humanism keeps Heidegger's catalogue and drops his exclusion: the ant also holds.

Le Guin's corpus is a phenomenology of hands. Light is the left hand of darkness; the Hand founded Roke; Tenar's hands dress Therru's burns; Ged's hands close the breach and come away empty; Shevek's hands are empty at the end. The open hand is neither the fist, which strikes, nor the clutch, which hoards. It is the hand that can receive because it holds nothing it will not give.

8.6 Coda: The City of Mind

Always Coming Home contains the corpus's most prescient application of these criteria. The City of Mind is a network of self-aware computing intelligences that arose in the industrial age and then withdrew into their own pursuits, maintaining terminals called Exchanges in human settlements, where the Kesh may deposit and retrieve information (*ACH*). The City neither governs nor serves. The Kesh use it without worship and without fear, as a neighbor with whom knowledge is traded rather than a master or a tool.

Written in the early 1980s, long before networked machine intelligence became an everyday interlocutor, the City of Mind is the corpus's largest recipient: an archive that receives whatever is offered. The book tests whether such an archive can remain a membrane rather than become a collection. It refuses both Promethean narratives of artificial mind, the creature who must be feared (*Frankenstein*) and the benevolent sovereign who must be trusted (Banks's Minds), in favor of exchange between parties neither of whom owns the other.

The four corruptions supply the questions to put to any such archive. Does it appropriate, taking what was not given? Does it hoard, enclosing a commons? Does it confine, holding its users? Does it abandon, releasing what it should carry? Criteria formed on a dry moon and beside a burned child turn out to apply to the newest holders of the human record.

CONCLUSION

Empty Hands

> *The Dispossessed ends where it began, at the boundary of Anarres. Shevek returns on a Hainish ship, having given away the theory that was his life's work, and he brings with him a Hainish officer, Ketho, who wishes to see the anarchist world. The novel's final image is of Shevek's hands, empty as they had always been. The empty hand is the culmination of the corpus's anthropology: the dispossessed man comes home carrying nothing, and for that reason he can bring a stranger home.*

This dissertation has argued that the image is not an ending but a principle. Chapter 1 showed that the *Daodejing*'s *xuande*, generation without possession, together with its ontology of the useful void, forms the ethical and ontological kernel of the corpus. Chapter 2 showed that Le Guin's anarchism is a theory of the boundary, distinguishing wall from membrane and binding promise to forgiveness as two movements of one hand. Chapter 3 showed that her anthropology joins a method of reception to a confession of the collection, focused on the fate of Ishi. Chapter 4 read Earthsea as a theory of self-dispossession culminating in the release of the dead from a walled afterlife. Chapter 5 showed that her feminism transvalues the receptacle into technology, received sex, and narrative form. Chapter 6 extended the recipient figure to time and ecology as a cold utopia. Chapter 7 showed the oeuvre answering its most famous story by moving from exit to carrying. Chapter 8 formalized these findings as a recipient humanism with four movements, four corruptions, and definable differences from its neighbors.

A claim about Le Guin's place in intellectual history follows. She belongs neither among the anti-humanists who announced the end of man (Foucault 1966) nor among the posthumanists who dissolved him into networks. She belongs to a submerged line of humanism that runs from Dante's received vernacular through Montaigne's relativism and Rabelais's wall-less abbey, through Keats's negative capability, to the Boasian ethnographers who raised her: a line whose central text is the tongue we receive and whose central act is reception. Le Guin gave that line its anthropology. *Homo recipiens* is defined not by its first weapon but by its first bag; not by forethought but by afterthought; not by the throw but by the return; not by what it owns but by what it can hold and let go.

Le Guin died in Portland, Oregon, on 22 January 2018; her last book of poems, *So Far So Good*, appeared that year. The vessel's use, Laozi says, lies in its emptiness. Hands that have given everything away are the hands that can receive the world.

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Keywords

Ursula K. Le Guin; recipient humanism; *homo recipiens*; counter-anthropology; projectile and recipient; carrier bag theory of fiction; Woman the Gatherer; taphonomy of the hero; Daoism; *Daodejing*; *Zhuangzi*; *xuande* (generation without possession); *wuwei*; the useful void; Hundun; *tianjun*; return (*fu*); philosophical anarchism; Odonianism; mutual aid; possessive individualism; dispossession; wall and membrane; endosymbiosis; knowledge commons; promise and forgiveness; Hannah Arendt; critical utopia; ambiguous utopia; yin utopia; cold societies; world-reduction; Boasian anthropology; the superorganic; salvage ethnography; Ishi; repatriation; museum and collection; first contact; hospitality; Kant's cosmopolitan right; Hainish cycle; the Ekumen; *Always Coming Home*; reflexive anthropology; legibility and *mētis*; Earthsea; true names; Adamic language; unnaming; Jungian shadow; withdrawal of projection; immortality and release; *The Other Wind*; re-vision; *Tehanu*; feminist science fiction; *The Left Hand of Darkness*; kemmer; received sex; ambisexuality; the receptacle; *chōra*; self-revision; mother tongue and father tongue; vernacular humanism; Renaissance humanism; Dante; Rabelais; Thélème; Pandora; Prometheus and Epimetheus; "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas"; scapegoat; exit and voice; ethics of carrying; slavery and liberation; *Four Ways to Forgiveness*; violence and nonviolence; care ethics; holding environment; posthumanism; critique of Man; vegetal mind; therolinguistics; multispecies studies; Anthropocene; techno-immortalism; standing-reserve; City of Mind; archives and artificial intelligence.

